

Differential Splicing from Equivalence-Class Counts

Overview

Questions and unit of analysis

The analysis asks two distinct questions:

1. Does local splice-path usage differ by experimental condition within a cell type?
2. Does local splice-path usage differ across cell types within the same mice?

The primary analysis aggregates cells into *mouse-by-condition-by-cell-type pseudobulks* and models their observed paired-primer equivalence-class (EC) counts directly. Biological replication is represented by mouse random effects; cells are never treated as independent condition replicates.

A splice block is a local region between constitutive exonic anchors. Transcripts that take the same path through that region are collapsed to one subisoform. This targets local splicing choices, which can be identifiable even when the corresponding full-length isoforms are not.

For condition effects, each hypothesis is indexed by a splice block and a cell type. It is an omnibus test of

$$H_0 : \text{mean path usage is equal across the included conditions.}$$

Only conditions represented by at least three mouse pseudobulks are included. With two conditions and two paths, this is a precision-weighted differential-PSI test. With more conditions or paths, all condition coefficients and path log-ratios are tested jointly.

For cell-type effects, each hypothesis is indexed by a nonredundant splice-path partition. It is an omnibus test of equal path usage across the included cell types while condition is an unrestricted nuisance fixed effect and mouse is a random effect. Cell types must be represented in at least three mice. Both contrasts require at least 10 modeled gene UMIs per retained pseudobulk. The cell-type and condition hypothesis families are reported separately.

Workflow

The primary analysis proceeds in five steps:

1. Construct local splice blocks from the isoform annotation and map every supported isoform to a local path.
2. Aggregate paired oligo(dT) and random-hexamer EC counts within each mouse, condition, and cell type while retaining separate primer maps.
3. For each block, construct nested fixed-effect tensors that absorb all isoform directions orthogonal to the tested path contrast.

4. Fit multinomial and logistic-normal multinomial EC GLMMs with full-covariance variational posteriors, warm-starting each alternative from its fitted null.
5. Calibrate the nested objective gain by null simulation, cross-fitted tail modeling, and a global leave-block-out empirical null CDF; then apply BH separately to cell-type and condition hypotheses.

Path-estimate Gaussian, compositional, Dirichlet–multinomial, GEE, Laplace, cell-resolved, and joint-test analyses are supporting comparisons and appear in the appendices. They are not separate versions of the primary test.

Notation and Dimensions

An *equivalence class* (EC) is a set of isoforms compatible with one UMI. An EC count is therefore observed, whereas its allocation among compatible isoforms is latent. A *splice path* is an ordered local exon chain between two constitutive anchors. A *subisoform* is the set of full-length isoforms taking the same path through one block. PSI means percent spliced in; for two paths it is one component of the path-composition vector. ILR means isometric log-ratio, an orthonormal coordinate system for a composition.

Let $g = g(b)$ denote the gene containing block b , and let $\mathcal{I}_g$ be the set of isoforms retained by the paired-primer model and assigned to gene g by the isoform-to-gene table. Define $T_g = |\mathcal{I}_g| \in \mathbb{N}$. This is a gene-level set, not the set of isoforms whose exons overlap the block, and it is therefore shared by every block of the gene. Let $\mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}} \subseteq \mathcal{I}_g$ be the retained, annotated spliced isoforms represented in the block’s GTF-derived path map. Isoforms in $\mathcal{I}_g \setminus \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}$, including modeled unspliced precursors, remain nuisance isoforms in the EC likelihood.

Let $I_b, S_b \in \mathbb{N}$ be the numbers of qualifying pseudobulks and represented spliced paths for block b , with $S_b \geq 2$. Then $d_b = S_b - 1 \in \mathbb{N}$ is its number of independent path contrasts. Define $r_g = T_g - 1$. There are $P = 2$ primer protocols, and primer p has $K_{gp} \in \mathbb{N}$ ECs for gene g . The principal symbols in the primary model are:

symbol	dimension or domain	meaning
b	$\{1, \dots, \mathcal{B}\}$	splice-block index
i	$\{1, \dots, I_b\}$	pseudobulk index within block b
p	$\{1, \dots, P\}$	primer-protocol index
t	$\{1, \dots, T_g\}$	isoform index within gene $g(b)$
s	$\{1, \dots, S_b\}$	splice-path index
$\mathbf{c}_{gip}$	$\mathbb{N}_0^{K_{gp}}$	observed pseudobulk EC counts
A_{gp}	$\mathbb{R}_+^{K_{gp} \times T_g}$	weighted EC-by-isoform map
$\boldsymbol{\eta}_{gi,-}$	$\mathbb{R}^{r_g}$	free isoform logits
$\mathbf{q}_{gip}$	$\Delta^{K_{gp}-1}$	primer-specific EC probabilities
Q_b	$\mathbb{R}^{S_b \times d_b}$	Helmert ILR basis
H_b	$\mathbb{R}^{r_g \times d_b}$	tested block-path basis
N_b	$\mathbb{R}^{r_g \times (T_g - S_b)}$	orthogonal nuisance basis
$\mathbf{u}_{gm}$	$\mathbb{R}^{r_g}$	mouse random effect
$\mathbf{e}_{gi}$	$\mathbb{R}^{r_g}$	logistic-normal row effect

Here $\mathcal{B} \in \mathbb{N}$ is the number of blocks, $\mathbb{N}_0 = \{0, 1, \dots\}$, $\Delta^{S_b-1} = \{\mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{S_b} : \mathbf{1}'\mathbf{v} = 1\}$, and $\mathbb{S}_+^k$ is the set of symmetric positive-semidefinite $k \times k$ matrices. Bold lower-case symbols are vectors, upper-case

symbols are matrices, $\mathbf{1}_k \in \mathbb{R}^k$ is a vector of ones, $\mathbf{0}_k \in \mathbb{R}^k$ is a vector of zeros, $I_k \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times k}$ is the identity, $\odot$ is elementwise multiplication, and $(\cdot)^+$ is the Moore–Penrose pseudoinverse.

Helmert basis and ILR coordinates

The simplex has only $d_b = S_b - 1$ free directions because path proportions sum to one. The Helmert matrix Q_b is a fixed orthonormal basis for the sum-zero subspace:

$$Q_b' Q_b = I_{d_b}, \quad Q_b' \mathbf{1}_{S_b} = \mathbf{0}_{d_b}.$$

Using one-based row $r \in \{1, \dots, S_b\}$ and column $j \in \{1, \dots, d_b\}$, its entries are

$$(Q_b)_{rj} = \begin{cases} 1/\sqrt{j(j+1)}, & r \leq j, \\ -j/\sqrt{j(j+1)}, & r = j+1, \\ 0, & r > j+1. \end{cases}$$

For any strictly positive $\psi_{bi} \in \Delta^{S_b-1}$, the ILR coordinate is $\mathbf{y}_{bi} = Q_b' \log \psi_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$, where the logarithm is elementwise. For $S_b = 2$, $Q_b = (1, -1)'/\sqrt{2}$ and $y_{bi} = \log(\psi_{bi1}/\psi_{bi2})/\sqrt{2}$. Thus a two-path ILR test is a scaled log-odds, or differential-PSI, test.

Primary EC-count GLMMs

Observed data and primer-specific EC probabilities

Fix a gene g and one of its splice blocks b . Let $T_g \in \mathbb{N}$ be the number of EC-supported isoforms and $r_g = T_g - 1$ the number of free reference-logit coordinates. There are $I_b \in \mathbb{N}$ retained pseudobulks and $M_b \in \mathbb{N}$ represented mice. For primer protocol $p \in \{1, 2\}$, let $K_{gp} \in \mathbb{N}$ be the number of retained ECs,

$$\mathbf{c}_{gip} \in \mathbb{N}_0^{K_{gp}}, \quad n_{gip} = \mathbf{1}_{K_{gp}}' \mathbf{c}_{gip} \in \mathbb{N}_0, \quad A_{gp} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{K_{gp} \times T_g}.$$

Here A_{gpkt} is the fixed compatibility or conditional weight of EC k for isoform t . Oligo(dT) and random-hexamer observations have separate count vectors and A_{gp} matrices, so primer-specific positional coverage enters the likelihood without changing the underlying isoform composition. Let $\boldsymbol{\eta}_{gi} = (\boldsymbol{\eta}'_{gi,-}, 0)' \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g}$ append a zero reference-isoform logit and define

$$q_{gipk}(\boldsymbol{\eta}_{gi}) = \frac{\sum_{t=1}^{T_g} A_{gpkt} \exp(\eta_{git})}{\sum_{h=1}^{K_{gp}} \sum_{t=1}^{T_g} A_{gph t} \exp(\eta_{git})}, \quad \mathbf{q}_{gip} \in \Delta^{K_{gp}-1}.$$

Conditioning on each observed primer total removes library size from the composition likelihood. An EC may be compatible with multiple isoforms; there is no preliminary allocation of its count to a transcript or path. Unsupported isoforms and ECs not assigned to g are excluded, but every supported isoform of g , including an unspliced nuisance isoform, remains in every block likelihood for that gene.

Multinomial EC GLMM

Let $m(i) \in \{1, \dots, M_b\}$ denote the mouse for row i . The multinomial EC GLMM is

$$\mathbf{c}_{gip} \mid \boldsymbol{\eta}_{gi} \sim \text{Multinomial}\{n_{gip}, \mathbf{q}_{gip}(\boldsymbol{\eta}_{gi})\}, \quad (1)$$

$$\boldsymbol{\eta}_{gi,-} = \mathcal{F}_{bi}(\boldsymbol{\beta}_b) + \mathbf{u}_{g,m(i)}, \quad (2)$$

$$\mathbf{u}_{gm} \sim N(\mathbf{0}_{r_g}, \sigma_g^2 I_{r_g}), \quad \mathbf{u}_{gm} \in \mathbb{R}^{r_g}, \quad \sigma_g > 0. \quad (3)$$

The same mouse effect enters both primer halves and every pseudobulk from that mouse. The fixed predictor $\mathcal{F}_{bi}(\boldsymbol{\beta}_b) \in \mathbb{R}^{r_g}$ is a tensor design defined below. Thus the model uses observed EC counts, preserves gene-wide ambiguity, and tests a local block contrast without first estimating a response vector.

Logistic-normal EC GLMM

The logistic-normal extension adds one isotropic residual composition effect per pseudobulk:

$$\boldsymbol{\eta}_{gi,-} = \mathcal{F}_{bi}(\boldsymbol{\beta}_b) + \mathbf{u}_{g,m(i)} + \mathbf{e}_{gi}, \quad (4)$$

$$\mathbf{e}_{gi} \sim N(\mathbf{0}_{r_g}, \tau_g^2 I_{r_g}), \quad \mathbf{e}_{gi} \in \mathbb{R}^{r_g}, \quad \tau_g > 0. \quad (5)$$

The multinomial observation model is otherwise unchanged. The same $\mathbf{e}_{gi}$ enters the oligo(dT) and random-hexamer likelihood terms because it perturbs the latent isoform composition rather than primer-specific EC probabilities. It therefore represents correlated extra-multinomial variation across the paired primer halves. The multinomial model is the special case $\tau_g = 0$. This logistic-normal construction is the primary overdispersion model; the direct EC Dirichlet-multinomial is retained only as an appendix sensitivity analysis.

Block contrast and nested fixed-effect tensors

Let $\pi_b(t) \in \{-1, 1, \dots, S_b\}$ be isoform t 's represented path, where -1 marks an isoform retained only as a likelihood nuisance. Start from the Helmert basis $Q_b \in \mathbb{R}^{S_b \times d_b}$, assign its path row to every mapped isoform and a zero row to every nuisance isoform, and center each column over the T_g isoforms. Converting from full logits to reference logits gives the tested basis

$$H_b \in \mathbb{R}^{r_g \times d_b}.$$

Let $N_b \in \mathbb{R}^{r_g \times (T_g - S_b)}$ be a basis for the reference-logit subspace orthogonal to H_b . The columns of $[N_b \ H_b] \in \mathbb{R}^{r_g \times r_g}$ span every free isoform-logit direction. Consequently, nuisance effects in N_b cannot express the tested local path contrast, while the alternative remains unrestricted after the H_b columns are added.

Let $Z_b \in \mathbb{R}^{I_b \times q_0}$ be the nuisance design and $W_b \in \mathbb{R}^{I_b \times q_1}$ the treatment-coded tested design. The nested predictors are

$$\mathcal{F}_{bi}^{(0)} = B'_0 Z'_{bi} + \sum_{j=1}^{q_1} W_{bij} N_b \boldsymbol{\alpha}_{bj}, \quad (6)$$

$$\mathcal{F}_{bi}^{(1)} = \mathcal{F}_{bi}^{(0)} + \sum_{j=1}^{q_1} W_{bij} H_b \boldsymbol{\gamma}_{bj}, \quad (7)$$

where $B_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{q_0 \times r_g}$, $\alpha_{bj} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g - S_b}$, and $\gamma_{bj} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$. The null sets every $\gamma_{bj} = \mathbf{0}_{d_b}$; the alternative adds $q_1 d_b$ block-path coefficients. In implementation these expressions are stored as tensors $\mathcal{X}_b^{(h)} \in \mathbb{R}^{I_b \times r_g \times a_h}$, $h \in \{0, 1\}$, and evaluated as $\mathcal{F}_{bi}^{(h)} = \mathcal{X}_{bi}^{(h)} \beta_b^{(h)}$.

The two biological tests differ only in Z_b and W_b :

- For the cell-type test, Z_b is a one-hot condition design and W_b has $J_b - 1$ cell-type columns. The tested dimension is $(J_b - 1)d_b$. All condition-by-isoform effects and cell-type effects orthogonal to the block contrast are present under the null.
- For condition within cell type, the data are restricted to one cell type, $Z_b = \mathbf{1}_{I_b}$, and W_b has $C_b^{\text{cond}} - 1$ condition columns. The tested dimension is $(C_b^{\text{cond}} - 1)d_b$. Each retained condition must be represented by at least three mice.

Distinct annotated blocks can induce the same partition after unsupported isoforms are removed. Before fitting or BH correction, tests are therefore deduplicated by gene, supported isoform set, canonical path partition, covered rows, and tested factor levels.

Full-covariance variational fitting

For mouse m , let $h_{gm} \in \mathbb{N}$ be its number of retained rows. In the multinomial model define $\mathbf{z}_{gm} = \mathbf{u}_{gm} \in \mathbb{R}^{r_g}$. In the logistic-normal model,

$$\mathbf{z}_{gm} = (\mathbf{u}'_{gm}, \mathbf{e}'_{gi_1}, \dots, \mathbf{e}'_{gi_{h_{gm}}})' \in \mathbb{R}^{L_{gm}}, \quad L_{gm} = (1 + h_{gm})r_g.$$

The prior covariance is

$$P_{gm} = \text{diag}(\sigma_g^2 I_{r_g}, \tau_g^2 I_{h_{gm} r_g}) \in \mathbb{S}_{++}^{L_{gm}},$$

with the residual block omitted for the multinomial model. The variational family factorizes across mice but has unrestricted covariance within mouse:

$$Q(\mathbf{z}_g) = \prod_{m=1}^{M_b} N(\mathbf{z}_{gm}; \boldsymbol{\mu}_{gm}, \Sigma_{gm}), \quad \Sigma_{gm} \in \mathbb{S}_{++}^{L_{gm}}.$$

Every Σ_{gm} is parameterized by a lower Cholesky factor with an exponentiated diagonal. It captures posterior dependence among isoform logits and, in the logistic-normal model, between the shared mouse effect and all residuals from that mouse. It does not add an unstructured covariance parameter to the generative model.

The multinomial likelihood uses the analytic tilted log-sum-exp bound. For a Gaussian logit vector with mean $\mathbf{m} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g}$, covariance $V \in \mathbb{S}_{++}^{T_g}$, and local coordinate $\mathbf{a} \in \Delta^{T_g-1}$,

$$E \log \sum_t \exp(\eta_t) \leq \frac{1}{2} \mathbf{a}' V \mathbf{a} + \log \sum_t \exp\{m_t + \frac{1}{2} V_{tt} - (V \mathbf{a})_t\}, \quad (8)$$

$$\mathbf{a} = \text{softmax}\{\mathbf{m} + \frac{1}{2} \text{diag}(V) - V \mathbf{a}\}. \quad (9)$$

The local coordinate is iterated for 25 fixed-point updates. The Gaussian KL term is exact:

$$\text{KL}(Q_m \| P_m) = \frac{1}{2} [\text{tr}(P_m^{-1} \Sigma_m) + \boldsymbol{\mu}'_m P_m^{-1} \boldsymbol{\mu}_m - L_{gm} + \log |P_m| - \log |\Sigma_m|].$$

Summing bounded expected log likelihoods and subtracting these KL terms gives the optimized objective $\mathcal{L}_b^{(h)} \in \mathbb{R}$. JAX supplies 64-bit gradients; bounded L-BFGS runs for at most 300 iterations per attempt. If the convergence criterion is not met, fitting resumes from the complete previous parameter vector for up to three retries. The alternative copies the fitted null fixed effects, variational means, Cholesky factors, and variance parameters, initializes only the new block coefficients to zero, and then optimizes. This warm start keeps the nested objective comparison on the same local branch.

Algorithm 1 Fit one multinomial or logistic-normal block EC GLMM test

Require: Paired counts $\mathbf{c}_{gip}$, maps A_{gp} , block path map π_b , labels, mouse indices, and model type

Ensure: Nested-fit statistic T_b and fitted null for simulation

- 1: Retain rows with at least 10 modeled gene UMIs and enforce the three-mouse representation rules.
 - 2: Construct H_b , N_b , and deduplicate the supported partition.
 - 3: Build $Z_b, W_b, \mathcal{X}_b^{(0)}, \mathcal{X}_b^{(1)}$ for the chosen cell-type or condition contrast.
 - 4: Initialize the null full-covariance posterior and variance parameters.
 - 5: **repeat**
 - 6: Iterate every tilted local coordinate for 25 updates.
 - 7: Evaluate the bounded ELBO and its 64-bit gradient.
 - 8: Update fixed effects, posterior means and Cholesky factors, and $\log \sigma_g$ plus optional $\log \tau_g$ by bounded L-BFGS.
 - 9: **until** convergence or the retry budget is exhausted
 - 10: Expand the null parameter vector with zero block coefficients and fit the alternative from this warm start.
 - 11: Set $T_b \leftarrow 2(\mathcal{L}_b^{(1)} - \mathcal{L}_b^{(0)})$.
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Null simulation and resolved-tail calibration

The optimized bound gain is not assigned a chi-squared reference. For each block, the fitted null generates five parametric-bootstrap replicates. Each replicate draws mouse effects and, for the logistic-normal model, row effects; forms primer-specific EC probabilities through A_{gp} ; preserves every observed n_{gip} ; draws multinomial EC counts; and refits both nested models with the same warm-start and stopping rules.

Raw empirical ranks within tested-dimension strata are calibrated at ordinary levels but do not resolve genome-wide tails: after deduplication their minimum p-values are approximately 4.5×10^{-4} , while BH requires values near 10^{-5} at the first ranks. Tail calibration therefore proceeds as follows. Within each likelihood and tested-dimension stratum, let u_s be the 90th percentile of bootstrap statistics. Excesses $T - u_s > 0$ follow a fitted generalized Pareto distribution with shape $\xi_s \in \mathbb{R}$ and scale $\beta_s > 0$. Entire block tests, including all their bootstrap replicates, are assigned to one of five folds. The tail model fitted on four folds maps statistics in the held-out fold to lower-tail scores $\rho \in (0, 1]$.

Residual GPD error is removed by a second empirical calibration. Let $\mathcal{R}_{-b}$ contain all cross-fitted null scores except scores generated for block b . The reported p-value is

$$p_b = \frac{1 + \sum_{\rho \in \mathcal{R}_{-b}} \mathbf{1}\{\rho \leq \rho_b\}}{1 + |\mathcal{R}_{-b}|}.$$

Every bootstrap replicate receives the same leave-block-out calibration. Aggregate null rejection

is audited at 0.05, 0.01, and 0.001, and 0.05 rejection is also checked by gene-depth and sample-count quartile. BH values are released only when aggregate and quartile 0.05 rejection rates lie in the prespecified interval 0.025–0.075. Thresholds 80%, 85%, 90%, and 95% are reported as a tail-model sensitivity analysis; a robust call must pass BH in all four analyses.

Algorithm 2 Cross-fitted calibration and genome-wide correction

Require: Observed statistics, fitted nulls, five null replicates per test, and tail threshold q

Ensure: Calibrated p-values and BH values

- 1: **for all** tests b **do**
 - 2: Simulate paired-primer counts from the fitted null while preserving observed primer totals; refit both nested models.
 - 3: **end for**
 - 4: Pool converged null statistics by likelihood and tested dimension; combine dimensions represented by fewer than 100 tests into a rare stratum.
 - 5: **for** $f = 1, \dots, 5$ **do**
 - 6: Fit each GPD tail using blocks outside fold f .
 - 7: Score observed and null statistics belonging to fold f .
 - 8: **end for**
 - 9: Recalibrate every score against the global leave-block-out null-score CDF within likelihood.
 - 10: Audit null rejection overall and by depth and sample count.
 - 11: Apply BH separately to the cell-type and within-cell-type condition families.
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Primary Results

At the 90% tail threshold, the nonredundant logistic-normal analysis tests 4,825 cell-type partitions and 14,833 block-by-cell-type condition hypotheses. Table 1 reports the results. The null rates at 0.05, 0.01, and 0.001 are from held-out block tests and therefore assess the complete tail-scoring and empirical-recalibration procedure.

Table 1: Primary logistic-normal EC GLMM results. Robust calls pass BH at every GPD threshold from 80% through 95%.

Contrast	Tests	Conv.	Nominal	FDR	Robust	Null < .05	Null < .01	Null < .001
Cell type	4,825	0.983	751	243	237	0.04994	0.00999	0.00098
Condition	14,833	1.000	1,415	0	0	0.04999	0.00999	0.00099

For cell type, 80%, 85%, 90%, and 95% GPD thresholds produce 243, 242, 243, and 239 calls; 237 occur in all four sets. The multinomial EC GLMM identifies 272 partitions at the 90% threshold and overlaps 229 of the 237 robust logistic-normal calls. The direct EC Dirichlet–multinomial appendix sensitivity identifies 59, with 44 partitions called by all three EC likelihoods. Thus the cell-type result is not specific to the logistic-normal variance model.

For condition within cell type, the same thresholds produce 27, 27, zero, and zero calls, with an empty intersection. At the primary 90% threshold the minimum FDR is 0.0637. The data therefore support strong cell-type DS but no condition DS event that is robust to the tail threshold.

Nonbootstrap Laplace sensitivity

Table 2 compares the analytic Laplace LRT and BIC Bayes-factor approximation with the completed mouse bootstrap analysis. A Laplace fit is retained only when the infinity norms of its scaled outer gradient and random-effect mode score are each at most 10^{-4} . Scaling the objective and gradient by the absolute initial objective changes neither the optimum nor the likelihood ratio, but prevents count depth from setting the numerical line-search scale.

Table 2: Nonbootstrap mouse cell-type sensitivity. BF counts use $\widehat{\text{BF}}_{10}^{\text{BIC}} > 10$; bootstrap calls use the primary GPD calibration.

Likelihood	Tests	Laplace conv.	LRT nominal	LRT BH	BF	Bootstrap BH
Multinomial	4,825	0.948	704	309	178	272
Logistic-normal	4,825	0.936	646	271	139	243

Restricting comparison to tests converged under both fitting strategies gives Laplace-versus-bootstrap statistic rank correlations 0.982 for multinomial and 0.964 for logistic-normal; p-value rank correlations are 0.950 and 0.922. The multinomial analyses share 243 BH calls, and the logistic-normal analyses share 204. Among these matched tests, the BF threshold selects 155 and 128 events, of which 140 and 116 are bootstrap BH calls. Applying the nominal chi-square reference to the existing variational-fit null simulations gives 0.05 rejection rates 0.0389 and 0.0374, indicating mild conservatism for that diagnostic rather than inflation.

The logistic-normal alternative estimates its observation-noise standard deviation at the lower numerical bound in 758 of 4,438 jointly converged fits. Because this nuisance variance is then on a boundary, its Wilks reference is less regular. The multinomial LRT is the cleaner nonbootstrap sensitivity, while the BF threshold supplies a smaller high-evidence subset; neither supersedes the empirically calibrated primary result without the mouse comparison above.

Matched external-method comparison

LeafCutter, scQuint, and MAJIQ are compared on junction evidence from the same cells and biological-replicate definitions used by the EC GLMM. Reads are aligned with STARsolo using the three-round Split-seq barcode geometry. Spliced alignments are restricted to unique genomic mappings and deduplicated by cell barcode, UMI, genomic start, and CIGAR. Junction UMIs are then summed within subject-by-cell-type pseudobulks. This prevents individual cells from being treated as independent biological replicates and gives every external method the same subject and cell-type support.

Condition tests compare conditions separately within each cell type. Cell-type tests use only subjects represented in both cell types. LeafCutter includes subject as a covariate for the paired cell-type tests. scQuint is run on the pseudobulk junction matrix because its differential-splicing interface has no covariate argument. MAJIQ v3 builds one common splice graph and PSI-coverage object from the pseudobulk BAMs, then applies its replicate-level Heterogen test with the conservative 95th percentile of the posterior-bootstrap Mann–Whitney p-value. MAJIQ and scQuint therefore use the matched replicates but cannot model their cell-type pairing. Each method receives BH correction within a pairwise contrast. For a cell-type-wide feature score, pairwise p-values are combined by Simes before a second BH correction. The comparison is run unchanged on both the mouse microglialess data and an independent human Parse Biosciences brain dataset.

A Alternative Models and Supporting Derivations

The main text defines the two primary EC-count GLMMs and their implemented test. This appendix records the path-estimate models, covariance approximations, alternative EC likelihoods, and inference benchmarks used to understand or validate that analysis.

Paired-primer EC likelihood

For block b , pseudobulk i , and primer p , define $N_{bip} = \mathbf{1}'_{E_{bp}} \mathbf{c}_{bip} \in \mathbb{N}_0$, $\mathbf{q}_{bip} = A_{bp} \boldsymbol{\theta}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{E_{bp}}$, and $Z_{bip} = \mathbf{1}'_{E_{bp}} \mathbf{q}_{bip} \in \mathbb{R}_+$. Conditional on the primer-specific UMI total,

$$\mathbf{c}_{bip} \mid N_{bip}, \boldsymbol{\theta}_{bi} \sim \text{Multinomial}(N_{bip}, \mathbf{q}_{bip}/Z_{bip}).$$

The oligo(dT) and random-hexamer protocols use separate A_{bp} matrices and likelihood terms. Their different isoform exposures therefore model primer-specific positional coverage without forcing a common bias profile.

The genome-wide hierarchical model supplies $\boldsymbol{\theta}_{bi}^{(0)} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{T_g}$. Let $s_b(t) \in \{1, \dots, S_b\}$ map isoform $t \in \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}$ to its path. The baseline spliced-isoform mass is the scalar $\omega_{bi}^{\text{sp}} = \sum_{t \in \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}} \theta_{bit}^{(0)} \in \mathbb{R}_+$. For $t \in \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}$, local refinement uses

$$\theta_{bit}(\boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi}) = \omega_{bi}^{\text{sp}} \frac{\theta_{bit}^{(0)} \exp\{(Q_b)_{s_b(t), \cdot} \boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi}\}}{\sum_{u \in \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}} \theta_{biu}^{(0)} \exp\{(Q_b)_{s_b(u), \cdot} \boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi}\}},$$

where $(Q_b)_{s, \cdot} \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times d_b}$. Nuisance-isoform abundances are unchanged. This preserves total spliced mass and the relative isoform mixture within each path while estimating only $\boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$.

Path response and inferential covariance

Each column of $C_b \in \{0, 1\}^{S_b \times T_g}$ corresponding to $t \in \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}$ contains one 1 in row $s_b(t)$; nuisance isoform columns are zero. Define

$$\mathbf{a}_{bi} = C_b \boldsymbol{\theta}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{S_b}, \quad \boldsymbol{\psi}_{bi} = \frac{\mathbf{a}_{bi}}{\mathbf{1}'_{S_b} \mathbf{a}_{bi}} \in \Delta^{S_b-1}, \quad \mathbf{y}_{bi} = Q_b' \log \boldsymbol{\psi}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}.$$

The perturbation parameterization implies $\mathbf{y}_{bi} = \mathbf{y}_{bi}^{(0)} + \boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi}$, where $\mathbf{y}_{bi}^{(0)} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$ is computed from the baseline.

Let $I_{\delta, bi} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}$ be the expected Fisher information of the summed paired-primer log likelihood with respect to $\boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi}$. The conditional covariance is $V_{bi}^{\text{cond}} = I_{\delta, bi}^{-1} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}$ when the information is positive definite. It conditions on the fitted total spliced mass, the isoform mixture within each path, and every nuisance-isoform abundance. Its only free directions are the d_b path perturbations.

Full-isoform nuisance (profile) covariance

The profile calculation is a covariance sensitivity analysis, not a second estimate of path usage. It retains the same $\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{T_g}$ obtained from the constrained local fit, but asks how uncertain its path ILRs would be if all T_g isoform log-abundances were locally free. Equivalently, after a smooth reparameterization into path ILRs and $T_g - d_b$ nuisance coordinates, it approximates the path-ILR block of the inverse Fisher information after profiling the nuisance coordinates. No unconstrained

isoform likelihood is optimized, so *profile* below means this local expected-Fisher approximation rather than an exact profile-likelihood fit.

Set $\boldsymbol{\eta}_{bi} = \log \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g}$, $D_{bi} = \text{diag}(\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}_{bi}) \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g \times T_g}$, $\mathbf{d}_{bp} = A'_{bp} \mathbf{1}_{E_{bp}} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g}$, and $\hat{\mathbf{q}}_{bip} = A_{bp} \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{E_{bp}}$, $\hat{Z}_{bip} = \mathbf{1}'_{E_{bp}} \hat{\mathbf{q}}_{bip} \in \mathbb{R}_+$, and $\mathbf{r}_{0,bip} = (\mathbf{d}_{bp} \odot \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}_{bi}) / \hat{Z}_{bip} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g}$. The primer-specific expected information is

$$I_{\eta,bip} = N_{bip} \left[\frac{D_{bi} A'_{bp} \text{diag}(\hat{\mathbf{q}}_{bip}^{-1}) A_{bp} D_{bi}}{\hat{Z}_{bip}} - \mathbf{r}_{0,bip} \mathbf{r}'_{0,bip} \right] \in \mathbb{S}_+^{T_g}.$$

The paired-primer information is $I_{\eta,bi} = \sum_{p=1}^P I_{\eta,bip} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{T_g}$.

The covariance must be propagated through the isoform-to-path map. Let $\omega_{bi}^{\text{sp}} = \sum_{t \in \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}} \hat{\theta}_{bit} \in \mathbb{R}_+$ and $a_{bis} = \sum_{t: s_b(t)=s} \hat{\theta}_{bit} \in \mathbb{R}_+$. Define $R_{bi} = \partial \log \psi_{bi} / \partial \boldsymbol{\eta}'_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{S_b \times T_g}$ entrywise by

$$(R_{bi})_{st} = \begin{cases} \mathbb{I}\{s_b(t) = s\} \hat{\theta}_{bit} / a_{bis} - \hat{\theta}_{bit} / \omega_{bi}^{\text{sp}}, & t \in \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}, \\ 0, & t \notin \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}. \end{cases}$$

Thus

$$J_{bi} = \frac{\partial \mathbf{y}_{bi}}{\partial \boldsymbol{\eta}'_{bi}} = Q'_b R_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b \times T_g}.$$

The multinomial likelihood necessarily has a global-scale null direction, and EC ambiguity can create additional null directions. Write the symmetric eigendecomposition

$$I_{\eta,bi} = U_{bi} \text{diag}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}_{bi}) U'_{bi},$$

where $U_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g \times T_g}$ is orthogonal and $\boldsymbol{\lambda}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g}$. An eigenvalue is treated as positive when $\lambda_{bit} > 10^{-8} \max_u |\lambda_{biu}|$. Let $\mathcal{P}_{bi} \subseteq \{1, \dots, T_g\}$ index these positive eigenvalues, let $\mathcal{N}_{bi}$ index the remainder, and let $U_{bi,+} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g \times |\mathcal{P}_{bi}|}$ and $U_{bi,0} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g \times |\mathcal{N}_{bi}|}$ contain the corresponding eigenvectors.

The path response is identifiable only if its Jacobian annihilates every information-null direction. The implementation requires

$$\|J_{bi} U_{bi,0}\|_F \leq 10^{-9} \max\{\|J_{bi}\|_F, 1\}.$$

If this fails, V_{bi}^{prof} is set to an infinite matrix and the estimate is excluded from profile testing. Otherwise,

$$V_{bi}^{\text{prof}} = J_{bi} U_{bi,+} \text{diag}(\boldsymbol{\lambda}_{bi,+}^{-1}) U'_{bi,+} J'_{bi} = J_{bi} I_{\eta,bi}^+ J'_{bi} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}.$$

Unlike V_{bi}^{cond} , this covariance allows EC-supported changes in within-path isoform mixtures, spliced mass, and nuisance isoforms to absorb information that would otherwise identify a path contrast. It is therefore the more conservative sensitivity calculation when those nuisance directions are weakly identified.

Cell-resolved likelihood

For cell h in pseudobulk i , let $\mathbf{c}_{bihp} \in \mathbb{N}_0^{E_{bp}}$, $N_{bihp} = \mathbf{1}'_{E_{bp}} \mathbf{c}_{bihp} \in \mathbb{N}_0$, and $\boldsymbol{\theta}_{bih}^{(0)} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{T_g}$ be its EC counts, total, and baseline. Every cell shares the same pseudobulk perturbation $\boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$, but its isoform vector $\boldsymbol{\theta}_{bih}(\boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi}) \in \mathbb{R}_+^{T_g}$ is normalized using its own baseline. The objective is the scalar

$$\ell_{bi}(\boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi}) = \sum_{h=1}^{H_{bi}} \sum_{p=1}^P \log \text{Multinomial} \left(\mathbf{c}_{bihp}; N_{bihp}, \frac{A_{bp} \boldsymbol{\theta}_{bih}(\boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi})}{\mathbf{1}'_{E_{bp}} A_{bp} \boldsymbol{\theta}_{bih}(\boldsymbol{\delta}_{bi})} \right).$$

Thus cells contribute assignment information but do not become biological replicates. Let $U_{bih} \in \mathbb{R}_+$ be the cell's total UMI count and $g_{bih} \in [0, 1]$ its decoded proportion for the block's gene. The scalar weight is $w_{bih} = U_{bih}g_{bih}$, and the reported pseudobulk composition is

$$\psi_{bi} = \frac{\sum_{h=1}^{H_{bi}} w_{bih} \psi_{bih}}{\sum_{h=1}^{H_{bi}} w_{bih}} \in \Delta^{S_b-1}.$$

Cell- and primer-specific Fisher information matrices in $\mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}$ are summed, inverted, and propagated through this weighted average to obtain $V_{bi} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}$.

Effective counts and compositional regression

Treating all gene UMIs as known path assignments is overconfident when ECs are ambiguous. For each fitted ψ_{bi} , define the unit-multinomial ILR covariance

$$G_{bi} = Q'_b \text{diag}(\psi_{bi}^{-1}) Q_b \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}.$$

The scalar effective count matches G_{bi}/n to the EC-derived V_{bi}^{cond} in Frobenius inner product $\langle U, W \rangle_F = \text{tr}(U'W)$, for $U, W \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b \times d_b}$:

$$n_{bi}^{\text{eff}} = \min \left\{ N_{bi}^{\text{gene}}, \frac{\langle G_{bi}, G_{bi} \rangle_F}{\langle G_{bi}, V_{bi}^{\text{cond}} \rangle_F} \right\} \in \mathbb{R}_+,$$

where $N_{bi}^{\text{gene}} \in \mathbb{N}_0$ is the gene UMI count. Fractional path counts are $\mathbf{x}_{bi} = n_{bi}^{\text{eff}} \psi_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{S_b}$, with $\mathbf{1}_{S_b}' \mathbf{x}_{bi} = n_{bi}^{\text{eff}}$.

For one block, stack $n = n_b \in \mathbb{N}$ observations in a design $X \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times k}$, where $k \in \mathbb{N}$, and coefficient matrix $\mathbf{B}_b \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times d_b}$. The mean composition $\boldsymbol{\mu}_{bi} \in \Delta^{S_b-1}$ is defined by reference-path logits

$$\log \frac{\mu_{bis}}{\mu_{biS_b}} = (X \mathbf{B}_b)_{is}, \quad s = 1, \dots, d_b.$$

The generalized Dirichlet-multinomial likelihood, extended to fractional counts through gamma functions, is

$$\mathbf{x}_{bi} \mid n_{bi}^{\text{eff}} \sim \text{DirichletMultinomial} \left(n_{bi}^{\text{eff}}, \kappa_b \boldsymbol{\mu}_{bi} \right),$$

where $\kappa_b \in \mathbb{R}_+ \cup \{\infty\}$ is a block-level concentration. Larger κ_b means less overdispersion; the endpoint $\kappa_b = \infty$ is exactly multinomial.

For nested designs $X_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times k_0}$ and $X_1 \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times k_1}$, with $k_1 \geq k_0$ and the first $k_0, k_1 \in \mathbb{N}$, and the first k_0 columns of X_1 equal to X_0 , let $\widehat{\ell}_0, \widehat{\ell}_1 \in \mathbb{R}$ be maximized scalar log likelihoods. The statistic and nominal degrees of freedom are

$$\Lambda_b = 2(\widehat{\ell}_1 - \widehat{\ell}_0) \in \mathbb{R}_+, \quad \nu_b = (k_1 - k_0)d_b \in \mathbb{N}_0.$$

The fixed-concentration analysis estimates $\widehat{\kappa}_{0b} \in \mathbb{R}_+ \cup \{\infty\}$ under X_0 and uses it under X_1 . The free-concentration sensitivity estimates $\widehat{\kappa}_{1b} \in \mathbb{R}_+ \cup \{\infty\}$ under X_1 . In the latter case both models contain one concentration nuisance parameter, so ν_b is unchanged. Both finite and exact multinomial endpoints are evaluated.

Gaussian mouse-replicate regression

For a condition test within one block and cell type, stack $\hat{\mathbf{y}}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$ over $n \in \mathbb{N}$ mice. Let $X_b \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times k}$, $k \in \mathbb{N}$, contain an intercept and condition indicators, $\mathbf{B}_b^{\text{GLS}} \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times d_b}$ be regression coefficients, and $\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$ be residuals:

$$\hat{\mathbf{y}}_{bi} = (X_{b,i} \mathbf{B}_b^{\text{GLS}})' + \boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{bi}, \quad \text{Var}(\boldsymbol{\epsilon}_{bi}) = V_{bi} + \tau_b^2 I_{d_b} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}.$$

Here $X_{b,i} \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times k}$, and $\tau_b^2 \in \mathbb{R}_+$ is residual between-mouse variance estimated by REML under the null. If $r_b \in \mathbb{N}$ non-reference condition columns are tested, their coefficients form $\boldsymbol{\beta}_b^{\text{test}} \in \mathbb{R}^{r_b d_b}$ with covariance $\Sigma_b^{\text{test}} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{r_b d_b}$. The Wald statistic is

$$W_b = (\boldsymbol{\beta}_b^{\text{test}})' (\Sigma_b^{\text{test}})^{-1} \boldsymbol{\beta}_b^{\text{test}} \in \mathbb{R}_+, \quad \nu_b^{\text{GLS}} = r_b d_b.$$

Paired cell-type test and permutations

For a cell-type test, let $M_b, L_b \in \mathbb{N}$ be the numbers of represented biological mice and cell types, respectively. The null design $X_{0b} \in \{0, 1\}^{n_b \times M_b}$ contains an intercept-coded set of mouse fixed effects. The alternative $X_{1b} \in \mathbb{R}^{n_b \times (M_b + L_b - 1)}$ appends treatment-coded cell-type indicators. Consequently $k_0 = M_b$, $k_1 = M_b + L_b - 1$, and $\nu_b = (L_b - 1)d_b$. The tested coefficient block is $\mathbf{B}_b^{\text{cell}} \in \mathbb{R}^{(L_b - 1) \times d_b}$, and

$$H_{0b} : \mathbf{B}_b^{\text{cell}} = 0 \quad \text{versus} \quad H_{1b} : \mathbf{B}_b^{\text{cell}} \neq 0.$$

Mouse effects absorb condition and every shift shared by cell types from the same mouse.

For $R = 500 \in \mathbb{N}$ permutations and $r \in \{1, \dots, R\}$, cell-type labels are shuffled only among rows from the same mouse, producing $X_{1b}^{(r)} \in \mathbb{R}^{n_b \times (M_b + L_b - 1)}$ and statistic $\Lambda_b^{(r)} \in \mathbb{R}_+$. Let $\varepsilon_b = 10^{-6} \max(1, |\Lambda_b|) \in \mathbb{R}_+$. The finite-permutation p-value is

$$p_b = \frac{1 + \sum_{r=1}^R \mathbb{I}\{\Lambda_b^{(r)} \geq \Lambda_b - \varepsilon_b\}}{R + 1} \in (0, 1], \quad R = 500.$$

The null coefficients and $\hat{\kappa}_{0b}$ are reused, but each permuted alternative is optimized. The tolerance counts numerically equal likelihood optima as ties. Benjamini–Hochberg correction is applied across canonical partitions with at least 30 pseudobulk rows.

Joint condition tests

ACAT combines $J \in \mathbb{N}$ component p-values $p_j \in (0, 1)$, $j = 1, \dots, J$, into the scalar

$$p_{\text{ACAT}} = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{\pi} \arctan \left[\frac{1}{J} \sum_{j=1}^J \tan\{\pi(1/2 - p_j)\} \right] \in (0, 1).$$

One level combines cell-type-specific p-values for a path partition; a second combines distinct partitions within a gene.

The shared-effect Gaussian model for block b uses $M \in \mathbb{N}$ mice indexed by $m \in \{1, \dots, M\}$, and $L_m \in \mathbb{N}$ cell types for mouse m , indexed by $c \in \{1, \dots, L_m\}$. Its response is $\mathbf{y}_{bmc} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$, design row $X_{bmc} \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times k}$, where $k \in \mathbb{N}$, coefficient matrix $\mathbf{B}_b \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times d_b}$, mouse random effect $\mathbf{u}_{bm} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$, and residual $\mathbf{e}_{bmc} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$:

$$\mathbf{y}_{bmc} = (X_{bmc} \mathbf{B}_b)' + \mathbf{u}_{bm} + \mathbf{e}_{bmc}.$$

The random terms satisfy $E(\mathbf{u}_{bm}) = E(\mathbf{e}_{bmc}) = \mathbf{0}_{d_b}$, $\text{Var}(\mathbf{u}_{bm}) = \tau_{\text{mouse}}^2 I_{d_b}$, and $\text{Var}(\mathbf{e}_{bmc}) = V_{bmc} + \tau_{\text{resid}}^2 I_{d_b}$. They are independent across mice, and residuals are independent across cell types conditional on $\mathbf{u}_{bm}$. Hence, for $c \neq c'$,

$$\text{Cov}(\mathbf{y}_{bmc}, \mathbf{y}_{bmc'}) = \tau_{\text{mouse}}^2 I_{d_b}, \quad \text{Var}(\mathbf{y}_{bmc}) = V_{bmc} + (\tau_{\text{mouse}}^2 + \tau_{\text{resid}}^2) I_{d_b},$$

where $V_{bmc} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}$, and $\tau_{\text{mouse}}^2, \tau_{\text{resid}}^2 \in \mathbb{R}_+$ are shared-mouse and residual variance components estimated by two-component REML under the no-condition model. Condition labels are permuted once per mouse and applied to all its cell types.

Multinomial-logit GLMM

The formal generalized linear mixed model uses the same shared-condition design as the joint Gaussian model but retains the multinomial response. Let $\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_{bmc} \in \mathbb{N}_0^{S_b}$ be integer path counts with $\tilde{n}_{bmc} = \mathbf{1}_{S_b}' \tilde{\mathbf{x}}_{bmc} \in \mathbb{N}$. They are obtained from the fractional effective counts $\mathbf{x}_{bmc}$ by rounding n_{bmc}^{eff} to the nearest positive integer and distributing the remaining molecules to paths by largest fractional remainder. This makes the conditional response a proper multinomial while changing each effective total by at most one.

For design row $X_{bmc} \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times k}$, fixed coefficients $\mathbf{B}_b \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times d_b}$, and mouse random intercept $\mathbf{u}_{bm} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$, define

$$\boldsymbol{\xi}_{bmc} = X_{bmc} \mathbf{B}_b + \mathbf{u}_{bm}' \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times d_b}, \quad \boldsymbol{\mu}_{bmc} = \text{softmax}\{(\boldsymbol{\xi}_{bmc}, 0)\} \in \Delta^{S_b-1}.$$

The final path is the reference category. The model is

$$\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_{bmc} \mid \mathbf{u}_{bm} \sim \text{Multinomial}(\tilde{n}_{bmc}, \boldsymbol{\mu}_{bmc}), \quad \mathbf{u}_{bm} \sim N(\mathbf{0}_{d_b}, \sigma_b^2 I_{d_b}),$$

where $\sigma_b^2 \in \mathbb{R}_+$ is re-estimated under both null and alternative. An isotropic random-effect covariance is used because some blocks have few mice; an unstructured $d_b \times d_b$ covariance would introduce $d_b(d_b + 1)/2$ variance parameters per block.

Let $\ell_{bm}(\mathbf{u}; \mathbf{B}_b, \sigma_b) \in \mathbb{R}$ be mouse m 's conditional multinomial log likelihood plus its Gaussian log density, and let

$$\hat{\mathbf{u}}_{bm} = \arg \max_{\mathbf{u} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}} \ell_{bm}(\mathbf{u}; \mathbf{B}_b, \sigma_b), \quad H_{bm} = - \frac{\partial^2 \ell_{bm}}{\partial \mathbf{u} \partial \mathbf{u}'} \Big|_{\hat{\mathbf{u}}_{bm}} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}.$$

The Laplace log marginal likelihood, up to constants common to nested models, is

$$\ell_b^{\text{Lap}}(\mathbf{B}_b, \sigma_b) = \sum_{m=1}^M \left[\ell_{bm}(\hat{\mathbf{u}}_{bm}; \mathbf{B}_b, \sigma_b) + \frac{d_b}{2} \log(2\pi) - \frac{1}{2} \log |H_{bm}| \right] \in \mathbb{R}.$$

The implementation differentiates this approximation through 30 damped Newton updates for every $\hat{\mathbf{u}}_{bm}$. The null contains cell-type intercepts; the alternative appends r_b condition columns. The likelihood-ratio statistic has nominal degrees of freedom $r_b d_b$.

Additional EC likelihoods and inference approximations

The path-count GLMM above treats estimated effective path counts as its response. The following restatement of the observed-EC model supplies context for the additional Dirichlet–multinomial, Laplace, CAVI, Monte Carlo, and Rényi inference comparisons. For gene g , let $T_g \in \mathbb{N}$ be its

number of supported isoforms, $d_g = T_g - 1$, $I_g \in \mathbb{N}$ the number of retained pseudobulks, $M_g \in \mathbb{N}$ the number of mice, and $P = 2$ the primer count. Primer p has $K_{gp} \in \mathbb{N}$ gene-assigned ECs. Define the observed counts $\mathbf{c}_{gip} \in \mathbb{N}_0^{K_{gp}}$, total $n_{gip} = \mathbf{1}'_{K_{gp}} \mathbf{c}_{gip} \in \mathbb{N}_0$, and fixed compatibility or conditional-weight matrix $A_{gp} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{K_{gp} \times T_g}$. Unsupported annotated isoforms and ECs not uniquely assigned to g are excluded.

Let $X_g \in \mathbb{R}^{I_g \times q}$ be the fixed-effect design, $B_g \in \mathbb{R}^{q \times d_g}$ its coefficient matrix, and $u_{gm} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_g}$ mouse m 's random isoform-logit intercept. With mouse index $m(i) \in \{1, \dots, M_g\}$, the reference-isoform parameterization is

$$\eta_{gi} = \{X_{gi}B_g + u'_{g,m(i)}, 0\} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g}, \quad u_{gm} \sim N(0, \sigma_g^2 I_{d_g}).$$

The probability of EC k from primer p is

$$q_{gipk}(\eta_{gi}) = \frac{\sum_{t=1}^{T_g} A_{gpkt} \exp(\eta_{git})}{\sum_{h=1}^{K_{gp}} \sum_{t=1}^{T_g} A_{gpht} \exp(\eta_{git})}, \quad \mathbf{q}_{gip} \in \Delta^{K_{gp}-1}.$$

Thus the two primers share B_g and u_{gm} , but retain distinct EC maps and positional-coverage weights. The conditional model is either

$$\mathbf{c}_{gip} \mid u_{g,m(i)} \sim \text{Multinomial}(n_{gip}, \mathbf{q}_{gip})$$

or

$$\mathbf{c}_{gip} \mid u_{g,m(i)} \sim \text{DirichletMultinomial}(n_{gip}, \kappa_g \mathbf{q}_{gip}), \quad \kappa_g \in \mathbb{R}_+.$$

The latter adds pseudobulk-level EC overdispersion. It is a direct Dirichlet–multinomial over EC categories, not a Dirichlet model over latent isoform allocations.

An alternative overdispersion model retains the multinomial observation but adds an isotropic observation-level logistic-normal effect. For pseudobulk i , let $e_{gi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_g}$ and replace the linear predictor by

$$\eta_{gi} = \{X_{gi}B_g + u'_{g,m(i)} + e'_{gi}, 0\}, \quad e_{gi} \sim N(0, \tau_g^2 I_{d_g}), \quad \tau_g \in \mathbb{R}_+.$$

The same e_{gi} enters both primer likelihoods, because it perturbs the underlying isoform composition rather than each primer's EC probabilities independently. Consequently this model allows correlated extra-multinomial variation across the two primer halves. It is a logistic-normal analogue of the Dirichlet–multinomial, not an identical distribution: its dispersion is isotropic in reference-logit coordinates, whereas the Dirichlet–multinomial has one concentration on the EC simplex.

Laplace inference maximizes the joint conditional density over $u_g \in \mathbb{R}^{M_g \times d_g}$. Its negative Hessian satisfies $H_g \in \mathbb{S}_+^{M_g d_g}$, and the marginal approximation adds the correction $-\frac{1}{2} \log |H_g|$. The outer fit optimizes B_g , σ_g , and, for the overdispersed model, κ_g .

Nonbootstrap Laplace inference

The block test uses the same fixed-effect tensors as the primary variational fit. Write the null tensor as $Z_{0b} \in \mathbb{R}^{I_g \times d_g \times p_{0b}}$ and the alternative as $Z_{1b} \in \mathbb{R}^{I_g \times d_g \times p_{1b}}$, where the first p_{0b} slices of Z_{1b} equal Z_{0b} . The remaining $q_b = p_{1b} - p_{0b} = r_b d_b^{\text{path}}$ coefficients are exactly the tested block-path interactions. For coefficient vector $\beta_b \in \mathbb{R}^{p_{jb}}$, the fixed nonreference-isoform logits for pseudobulk i are

$$\boldsymbol{\eta}_{gbi}^{\text{fix}} = Z_{jb,i,\cdot} \beta_b \in \mathbb{R}^{d_g}, \quad j \in \{0, 1\}.$$

Thus the likelihood still contains every supported gene isoform and EC; only the tested fixed-effect subspace is block specific.

Let $\widehat{\ell}_{0b}^{\text{Lap}}$ and $\widehat{\ell}_{1b}^{\text{Lap}}$ be the maximized Laplace marginal log likelihoods, including re-estimation of all shared variance parameters. The nonbootstrap likelihood-ratio statistic and nominal reference distribution are

$$D_b = 2\{\widehat{\ell}_{1b}^{\text{Lap}} - \widehat{\ell}_{0b}^{\text{Lap}}\}, \quad D_b \sim \chi_{q_b}^2.$$

The alternative starts from the null estimate with its q_b added coefficients set to zero. A BIC approximation to the alternative-versus-null Bayes factor uses the number M_g of independent mice rather than the number of pseudobulks:

$$\log \widehat{\text{BF}}_{10,b}^{\text{BIC}} = \frac{1}{2}\{D_b - q_b \log M_g\} \in \mathbb{R}.$$

This is not a prior-integrated Bayes factor. Both calculations require only the null and alternative fits, compared with one null and one alternative fit for every parametric-bootstrap replicate. Their calibration can fail when the number of mice is small, a variance estimate lies on its boundary, or the Laplace outer optimizer is inaccurate. They are therefore compared with the completed mouse bootstrap analysis before being used as a replacement for empirical calibration.

For variational inference, use the diagonal Gaussian family

$$Q(u_g) = \prod_{m=1}^{M_g} \prod_{j=1}^{d_g} N(u_{gmj}; \mu_{gmj}, s_{gmj}^2), \quad \mu_g, s_g \in \mathbb{R}^{M_g \times d_g}, \quad s_{gmj} > 0.$$

For the multinomial likelihood, latent EC-to-isoform responsibilities $r_{gipkt} \in [0, 1]$, with $\sum_t r_{gipkt} = 1$ on the support of A_{gpkt} , give the optimized lower bound

$$E_Q \left[\log \sum_t A_{gpkt} e^{\eta_{git}} \right] \geq \log \sum_t A_{gpkt} e^{E_Q \eta_{git}}.$$

The normalizer needs an upper bound. For one observation and primer, let $m_{gipt} = E_Q \eta_{git} + \log \sum_k A_{gpkt}$, $v_{gipt} = \text{Var}_Q(\eta_{git})$, and $a_{gip} \in \Delta^{T_g-1}$. The tilted softmax bound of Knowles and Minka is

$$E_Q \log \sum_{t=1}^{T_g} e^{\eta_{git} + \log \sum_k A_{gpkt}} \leq \frac{1}{2} \sum_t a_{gipt}^2 v_{gipt} + \log \sum_t \exp \left\{ m_{gipt} + \frac{1 - 2a_{gipt}}{2} v_{gipt} \right\},$$

where the local coordinate satisfies

$$a_{gip} = \text{softmax}\{m_{gip} + \frac{1}{2}(1 - 2a_{gip}) \odot v_{gip}\}.$$

Alternating the analytic responsibilities, this local fixed point, and the global Gaussian parameters maximizes a tractable lower bound on the multinomial evidence. The cited method is non-conjugate variational message passing rather than conjugate CAVI; here “tilted CAVI” refers only to this block-coordinate implementation.

The full-covariance extension factorizes only across mice. If mouse m has $q_{gm} \in \mathbb{N}$ observed pseudobulks, define its complete latent block

$$z_{gm} = (u'_{gm}, e'_{gi_1}, \dots, e'_{gi_{q_{gm}}})' \in \mathbb{R}^{L_{gm}}, \quad L_{gm} = (q_{gm} + 1)d_g,$$

where the e components are omitted in the model without observation noise. Its prior covariance is diagonal,

$$P_{gm} = \text{diag}(\sigma_g^2 I_{d_g}, \tau_g^2 I_{q_{gm} d_g}) \in \mathbb{S}_+^{L_{gm}},$$

but its posterior approximation is unrestricted within mouse,

$$Q(z_g) = \prod_{m=1}^{M_g} N(z_{gm}; \mu_{gm}, \Sigma_{gm}), \quad \mu_{gm} \in \mathbb{R}^{L_{gm}}, \quad \Sigma_{gm} \in \mathbb{S}_{++}^{L_{gm}}.$$

Thus full covariance describes posterior dependence among isoform logits and between a shared mouse effect and its pseudobulk residuals; it does not add an unstructured covariance parameter to the generative model.

For a block-specific cell-type test, the EC likelihood still contains all T_g supported isoforms of gene g ; the response is not reduced to path counts. Let $J_b \in \mathbb{N}$ be the number of represented cell types, $Z_b \in \mathbb{R}^{I_g \times q_0}$ the one-hot condition design, and $W_b \in \mathbb{R}^{I_g \times (J_b - 1)}$ the treatment-coded cell-type design. Define $D_b \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g \times d_b}$ by assigning row t the corresponding row of Q_b when isoform t takes a represented path through block b , and assigning it $\mathbf{0}'_{d_b}$ when the isoform is outside the block map. Center the columns of D_b , and let $N_b^{\text{full}} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g \times (T_g - S_b)}$ be an orthonormal basis for the subspace orthogonal to both its columns and $\mathbf{1}_{T_g}$. In reference-isoform coordinates, define

$$H_b = D_{b,1:(T_g-1),:} - \mathbf{1}_{T_g-1} D_{b,T_g,:} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_g \times d_b}, \quad N_b = N_{b,1:(T_g-1),:}^{\text{full}} - \mathbf{1}_{T_g-1} N_{b,T_g,:}^{\text{full}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_g \times (T_g - S_b)}.$$

The free-logit predictor is

$$\eta_{gi,-} = Z_{bi} B_{g0} + \sum_{j=1}^{J_b-1} W_{bij} (N_b \alpha_{bj} + H_b \gamma_{bj}) + u_{g,m(i)} + e_{gi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_g},$$

where $B_{g0} \in \mathbb{R}^{q_0 \times d_g}$ contains unrestricted condition effects, $\alpha_{bj} \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g - S_b}$ contains cell-type nuisance effects orthogonal to the tested block directions, and $\gamma_{bj} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$ is cell type j 's block-path contrast. The e_{gi} term is present only in the logistic-normal sensitivity model. The null estimates every α_{bj} but sets all $\gamma_{bj} = \mathbf{0}_{d_b}$; the alternative has $(J_b - 1)d_b$ additional coefficients. The combined columns of N_b and H_b span all d_g isoform-logit directions, so the alternative permits unrestricted cell-type isoform composition while the null absorbs every direction orthogonal to the tested path contrast. This construction makes the EC GLMM a per-block test while preserving gene-wide ambiguity and nuisance mass.

For row i , let $R_{gi} \in \{0, 1\}^{d_g \times L_{g,m(i)}}$ select and sum its mouse and observation effects. Its free-logit covariance is $R_{gi} \Sigma_{g,m(i)} R_{gi}' \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_g}$; append a zero row and column for the reference isoform to obtain $V_{gi} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{T_g}$. The correlated tilted bound replaces the variance vector in the diagonal expression. For $m \in \mathbb{R}^{T_g}$, $V \in \mathbb{S}_+^{T_g}$, and $a \in \Delta^{T_g-1}$,

$$E \log \sum_t e^{\eta_t} \leq \frac{1}{2} a' V a + \log \sum_t \exp\{m_t + \frac{1}{2} V_{tt} - (Va)_t\}, \quad a = \text{softmax}\{m + \frac{1}{2} \text{diag}(V) - Va\}.$$

The Gaussian KL term is analytic:

$$\text{KL}(Q_m \| P_m) = \frac{1}{2} [\text{tr}(P_m^{-1} \Sigma_m) + \mu_m' P_m^{-1} \mu_m - L_{gm} + \log |P_m| - \log |\Sigma_m|].$$

Each positive-definite Σ_m is represented by an unconstrained lower Cholesky factor with exponentiated diagonal. The full fit warm-starts from a diagonal variational posterior by copying its means and marginal variances and setting new off-diagonal entries to zero.

The direct EC Dirichlet–multinomial contains $\log \Gamma\{\kappa_g q_{gipk}(u) + c_{gipk}\}$, so the tilted softmax bound does not yield coordinate updates for it. Both likelihood families are therefore also fit with reparameterized Monte Carlo VI. If $w(u) = p(c, u)/Q(u)$, the optimized objective is the ELBO

$$\mathcal{L}_1 = E_Q \log w(u)$$

or the variational Rényi bound of order $\alpha \in (0, 1)$,

$$\mathcal{L}_\alpha = \frac{1}{1-\alpha} \log E_Q \{w(u)^{1-\alpha}\}.$$

The comparison uses $\alpha = 0.5$, antithetic Gaussian draws, and the same diagonal or full Gaussian family. Conditional on B_g, σ_g, κ_g , both the likelihood and Q factor by mouse. Writing the corresponding ratio as $w_m(u_{gm})$, the implementation evaluates the equivalent expression

$$\mathcal{L}_\alpha = \sum_{m=1}^{M_g} \frac{1}{1-\alpha} \log E_{Q_m} \{w_m(u_{gm})^{1-\alpha}\}.$$

This avoids the exponential importance-weight degeneracy caused by forming one product weight over all mice. Rényi VI is not called CAVI because its importance-weighted objective has no coordinate update under this model. For the full posterior with observation-level noise, directly optimizing a fixed set of Monte Carlo draws is ill-conditioned: the Cholesky factor can overfit sample correlations when L_{gm} is not small relative to the draw count. This variant is therefore fit with the analytic tilted objective; fresh antithetic draws evaluate its exact-likelihood ELBO and Rényi bound.

The block statistic is twice the optimized alternative-minus-null variational objective. Its reference distribution is empirical rather than χ^2 , because it compares optimized evidence bounds and can inherit approximation error. A synchronized label permutation is invalid here because the block null permits real cell-type nuisance effects in orthogonal isoform directions. Instead, a parametric bootstrap simulates mouse effects and optional observation effects from the fitted block null, generates paired-primer EC counts with the observed row totals, and refits both nested models. Each observed statistic is compared with a leave-block-out pool of bootstrap statistics matched by likelihood family and tested dimension $(J_b - 1)d_b$. Tested dimensions represented by fewer than 20 blocks are combined into a rare-dimension stratum within the same likelihood. Matching gene-depth quartiles fragmented the empirical tail enough to limit BH resolution in the genome-wide analysis. Depth is therefore an independent calibration audit rather than a pooling variable. With null pool $\mathcal{N}_{-b}$,

$$p_b = \frac{1 + \sum_{z \in \mathcal{N}_{-b}} \mathbf{1}\{z \geq T_b\}}{1 + |\mathcal{N}_{-b}|}.$$

Every bootstrap statistic is calibrated by the same leave-block-out rule. Benjamini–Hochberg values are reported for a likelihood only if these calibrated null p -values reject between 2.5% and 7.5% at level 0.05, both in aggregate and separately within each gene-depth quartile.

Liang–Zeger multinomial GEE

GEE specifies only the marginal mean and first two moments. It can therefore use the fractional effective counts directly. Define $\mathbf{p}_{bmc} = \mathbf{x}_{bmc}/n_{bmc}^{\text{eff}} \in \Delta^{S_b-1}$, and let $\mathbf{p}_{bmc,-} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$ omit the reference path. Its marginal mean uses the same reference-logit regression,

$$\boldsymbol{\mu}_{bmc} = \text{softmax}\{(X_{bmc}\mathbf{B}_b, 0)\}, \quad G_{bmc} = \text{diag}(\boldsymbol{\mu}_{bmc,-}) - \boldsymbol{\mu}_{bmc,-}'\boldsymbol{\mu}_{bmc,-} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}.$$

The working covariance of one proportion vector is $A_{bmc} = G_{bmc}/n_{bmc}^{\text{eff}} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}$. Let $L_{bmc} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b \times d_b}$ be its symmetric square root, and let

$$D_{bmc} = \frac{\partial \boldsymbol{\mu}_{bmc,-}}{\partial \text{vec}(\mathbf{B}_b)'} = [X_{bmc,1}G_{bmc} \cdots X_{bmc,k}G_{bmc}] \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b \times kd_b}.$$

For mouse m , stack its $q_m \in \mathbb{N}$ observed cell types into $\mathbf{p}_{bm,-} \in \mathbb{R}^{q_m d_b}$, mean $\boldsymbol{\mu}_{bm,-} \in \mathbb{R}^{q_m d_b}$, and derivative $D_{bm} \in \mathbb{R}^{q_m d_b \times kd_b}$. With $L_{bm} = \text{blockdiag}_c(L_{bmc})$ and exchangeable $R_m(\alpha_b) \in \mathbb{R}^{q_m \times q_m}$, the Liang–Zeger working covariance is

$$W_{bm} = \phi_b L_{bm} \{R_m(\alpha_b) \otimes I_{d_b}\} L_{bm}' \in \mathbb{S}_+^{q_m d_b}.$$

The scale $\phi_b \in \mathbb{R}_+$ and working correlation $\alpha_b \in (-1/(q_{\max} - 1), 1)$ are updated from whitened Pearson residuals. Coefficients solve

$$\sum_{m=1}^M D_{bm}' W_{bm}^{-1} (\mathbf{p}_{bm,-} - \boldsymbol{\mu}_{bm,-}) = \mathbf{0}_{kd_b}.$$

If $\mathbf{U}_{bm} = D_{bm}' W_{bm}^{-1} (\mathbf{p}_{bm,-} - \boldsymbol{\mu}_{bm,-}) \in \mathbb{R}^{kd_b}$ and $\mathcal{H}_b = \sum_m D_{bm}' W_{bm}^{-1} D_{bm} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{kd_b}$, the canonical cluster-robust covariance is

$$\widehat{\text{Var}}\{\text{vec}(\hat{\mathbf{B}}_b)\} = \mathcal{H}_b^+ \left(\sum_{m=1}^M \mathbf{U}_{bm} \mathbf{U}_{bm}' \right) \mathcal{H}_b^+ \in \mathbb{S}_+^{kd_b}.$$

The condition coefficients are tested by a robust Wald statistic. No small-sample sandwich correction is imposed; synchronized mouse-level permutations assess whether the canonical large- M reference is adequate.

Matched power benchmark

Power is evaluated only for partitions represented by exactly two conditions. For replicate r , condition labels are first permuted among mice. Let $z_{bmc}^{(r)} \in \{0, 1\}$ be the resulting non-reference condition indicator and let $\mathbf{v}_b \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$ be a reproducible random unit vector. For ILR effect $\gamma \in \{0.25, 0.5\}$, define

$$\mathbf{y}_{bmc}^{(r,\gamma)} = \mathbf{y}_{bmc} + \gamma z_{bmc}^{(r)} \mathbf{v}_b, \quad \boldsymbol{\psi}_{bmc}^{(r,\gamma)} = \text{softmax}\{Q_b \mathbf{y}_{bmc}^{(r,\gamma)}\}.$$

The shifted effective counts are $n_{bmc}^{\text{eff}} \boldsymbol{\psi}_{bmc}^{(r,\gamma)}$. Thus every method sees the same imposed ILR effect, observed effective depth, cell-type pattern, and mouse clustering. For each simulated alternative, null-calibrated power uses the finite-permutation rank of its statistic among synchronized null statistics for the same block and method. This event-matched calibration preserves dimension, depth, and cluster structure.

B Supporting Algorithms

All algorithms operate independently over canonical blocks unless a joint gene-level combination is stated. “Fit” below means bounded L-BFGS with analytic gradients and a fourfold iteration-limit retry after a warm start from the first endpoint.

Algorithm 3 Construct splice blocks and path maps

Require: K_g annotated spliced isoforms with exon chains; retained set $\mathcal{I}_g$, $|\mathcal{I}_g| = T_g$

Ensure: Blocks b , maps $C_b \in \{0, 1\}^{S_b \times T_g}$, and bases $Q_b \in \mathbb{R}^{S_b \times d_b}$

- 1: Split the gene at every annotated exon boundary into atomic intervals.
 - 2: Merge adjacent intervals exonic in every annotated isoform into constitutive anchors.
 - 3: Form internal blocks between consecutive anchors and terminal blocks using pseudo-anchors.
 - 4: **for all** candidate blocks b **do**
 - 5: Record each annotated isoform's ordered intervening exon chain.
 - 6: Assign identical chains to one path and restrict to $\mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}} \subseteq \mathcal{I}_g$.
 - 7: Remap represented path labels to $\{1, \dots, S_b\}$.
 - 8: **if** $S_b < 2$ **then**
 - 9: discard b
 - 10: **else**
 - 11: Set $(C_b)_{s_b(t), t} = 1$ for $t \in \mathcal{I}_b^{\text{sp}}$; leave nuisance columns zero.
 - 12: Construct the Helmert basis Q_b .
 - 13: **end if**
 - 14: **end for**
 - 15: Canonicalize the unordered isoform partition and retain one representative of equivalent blocks.
-

Algorithm 4 Fit one pseudobulk's local path composition

Require: Counts $c_{bip} \in \mathbb{N}_0^{E_{bp}}$, designs $A_{bp} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{E_{bp} \times T_g}$, baseline $\theta_{bi}^{(0)} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{T_g}$, C_b , and Q_b

Ensure: $\hat{\theta}_{bi}$, $\hat{\psi}_{bi}$, $\hat{y}_{bi}$, and V_{bi}^{cond}

- 1: Initialize $\delta_{bi} \leftarrow \mathbf{0}_{d_b}$.
 - 2: **if** $S_b = 2$ **then**
 - 3: Evaluate the fixed log-ratio grid and retain its best point.
 - 4: **end if**
 - 5: **function** OBJECTIVE(δ)
 - 6: Form $\theta_{bi}(\delta)$, preserving spliced mass and within-path isoform mixtures.
 - 7: **return** the negative sum of the $P = 2$ multinomial log likelihoods and its analytic gradient.
 - 8: **end function**
 - 9: Minimize OBJECTIVE(δ) by bounded L-BFGS on $[-20, 20]^{d_b}$.
 - 10: Set $\hat{\theta}_{bi} \leftarrow \theta_{bi}(\hat{\delta}_{bi})$.
 - 11: Set $\hat{\psi}_{bi} \leftarrow C_b \hat{\theta}_{bi} / (\mathbf{1}_{S_b}' C_b \hat{\theta}_{bi})$.
 - 12: Set $\hat{y}_{bi} \leftarrow Q_b' \log \hat{\psi}_{bi}$.
 - 13: Compute $I_{\delta, bi}$ by summing primer expected information.
 - 14: Apply the eigenvalue/null-space check to $(I_{\delta, bi}, I_{d_b})$; if identifiable, set $V_{bi}^{\text{cond}} = I_{\delta, bi}^{-1}$, otherwise set it to infinity.
-

Algorithm 5 Compute full-isoform nuisance (profile) covariance

Require: $\hat{\theta}_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}_+^{T_g}$, A_{bp} , N_{bip} , C_b , Q_b , relative threshold $r_{\text{eig}} = 10^{-8}$, and null tolerance $a_{\text{null}} = 10^{-9}$

Ensure: $V_{bi}^{\text{prof}} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{d_b}$ and an identifiability flag

- 1: **for** $p = 1, \dots, P$ **do**
 - 2: Compute $\hat{q}_{bip}$, $\hat{Z}_{bip}$, and $I_{\eta,bip} \in \mathbb{S}_+^{T_g}$.
 - 3: **end for**
 - 4: Set $I_{\eta,bi} \leftarrow \sum_p I_{\eta,bip}$.
 - 5: Compute path masses a_{bis} , spliced mass ω_{bi}^{sp} , and $R_{bi} = \partial \log \psi_{bi} / \partial \eta'_{bi}$.
 - 6: Set $J_{bi} \leftarrow Q'_b R_{bi}$.
 - 7: Eigendecompose $I_{\eta,bi} = U_{bi} \text{diag}(\lambda_{bi}) U'_{bi}$.
 - 8: Put t in $\mathcal{P}_{bi}$ when $\lambda_{bit} > r_{\text{eig}} \max_u |\lambda_{biu}|$, and put all other indices in $\mathcal{N}_{bi}$.
 - 9: **if** $\|J_{bi} U_{bi,0}\|_F > a_{\text{null}} \max\{\|J_{bi}\|_F, 1\}$ **then**
 - 10: Set $V_{bi}^{\text{prof}} \leftarrow \infty_{d_b \times d_b}$ and mark the response unidentified.
 - 11: **else**
 - 12: Set $V_{bi}^{\text{prof}} \leftarrow J_{bi} U_{bi,+} \text{diag}(\lambda_{bi,+}^{-1}) U'_{bi,+} J'_{bi}$.
 - 13: Mark the response identifiable.
 - 14: **end if**
-

Algorithm 6 Fit a cell-resolved pseudobulk path composition

Require: Cell EC vectors c_{bihp} , baselines $\theta_{bih}^{(0)}$, weights w_{bih} , and A_{bp} , C_b , Q_b

Ensure: One pseudobulk response $\hat{y}_{bi}$ and covariance V_{bi}

- 1: Allocate one shared $\delta_{bi} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_b}$.
 - 2: **for all** cells h and primers p **do**
 - 3: Perturb the cell's baseline, normalize its EC probabilities, and add its multinomial log likelihood and gradient.
 - 4: **end for**
 - 5: Optimize the summed objective over δ_{bi} .
 - 6: Compute each fitted $\hat{\psi}_{bih}$ and their normalized w_{bih} -weighted mean $\hat{\psi}_{bi}$.
 - 7: Sum cell-by-primer Fisher matrices and propagate their inverse through the weighted composition response to obtain V_{bi} .
 - 8: Set $\hat{y}_{bi} = Q'_b \log \hat{\psi}_{bi}$.
-

Algorithm 7 Gaussian condition or paired cell-type test

Require: Responses $\hat{\mathbf{y}}_{bi}$, covariances V_{bi} , mouse, condition, and cell-type labels; test type

Ensure: One Wald p-value for block b

- 1: **if** testing condition within a cell type **then**
 - 2: Retain conditions represented by at least three mice.
 - 3: Build full design $X_b \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times k}$ and reduced design $X_{0b} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times (k-r_b)}$.
 - 4: **else**
 - 5: Build mouse-effect design $X_{0b} \in \{0, 1\}^{n_b \times M_b}$.
 - 6: Append $L_b - 1$ cell-type columns to obtain $X_{1b} \in \mathbb{R}^{n_b \times (M_b + L_b - 1)}$.
 - 7: **end if**
 - 8: Require full column rank in both designs.
 - 9: Estimate τ_b^2 by REML under the reduced design using $V_{bi} + \tau_b^2 I_{d_b}$.
 - 10: Hold $\hat{\tau}_b^2$ fixed and fit the full design by GLS.
 - 11: Stack the tested coefficients and compute their Wald statistic W_b .
 - 12: Compare W_b with the applicable chi-squared reference.
 - 13: Calibrate by mouse-level condition permutations or within-mouse cell-type permutations, as appropriate.
-

Algorithm 8 Paired compositional cell-type test

Require: $\hat{\psi}_{bi}$, V_{bi}^{cond} , mouse and cell-type labels, and $R = 500$

Ensure: One exact permutation p-value p_b per canonical block

- 1: Keep converged, identifiable estimates satisfying the path floor and the three-mouse-per-cell-type requirement.
 - 2: Convert each $(\hat{\psi}_{bi}, V_{bi}^{\text{cond}})$ to n_{bi}^{eff} and $\mathbf{x}_{bi}$.
 - 3: Build X_{0b} from mouse effects and X_{1b} by appending cell-type effects.
 - 4: Fit the null coefficients and $\hat{\kappa}_{0b}$.
 - 5: Fit the observed alternative and compute Λ_b .
 - 6: **if** using fixed concentration **then**
 - 7: Set $\kappa_{1b} \leftarrow \hat{\kappa}_{0b}$.
 - 8: **else**
 - 9: Optimize $\hat{\kappa}_{1b}$ and compare the finite optimum with the exact multinomial endpoint.
 - 10: **end if**
 - 11: **for** $r = 1, \dots, R$ **do**
 - 12: Shuffle cell-type labels within each mouse to form $X_{1b}^{(r)}$.
 - 13: Reuse the null fit, refit the alternative, and store $\Lambda_b^{(r)}$.
 - 14: **end for**
 - 15: Compute the tolerance-aware finite-permutation rank p_b .
 - 16: Require $n_b \geq 30$, then apply BH across canonical blocks.
-

Algorithm 9 Liang–Zeger multinomial GEE condition test

Require: Fractional counts $\mathbf{x}_{bmc}$, design X_b , mouse labels, and tested condition columns

Ensure: Robust Wald statistic and p-value

- 1: Initialize $\mathbf{B}_b$ from independent multinomial regression and set $\alpha_b \leftarrow 0$, $\phi_b \leftarrow 1$.
 - 2: **repeat**
 - 3: Compute $\boldsymbol{\mu}_{bmc}$, G_{bmc} , A_{bmc} , and D_{bmc} for every observation.
 - 4: Whiten residuals by $A_{bmc}^{-1/2}$.
 - 5: Update ϕ_b from squared Pearson residuals and α_b from within-mouse Pearson cross-products.
 - 6: Construct every W_{bm} , quasi-score $\mathbf{U}_{bm}$, and sensitivity matrix $\mathcal{H}_b$.
 - 7: Update $\text{vec}(\mathbf{B}_b) \leftarrow \text{vec}(\mathbf{B}_b) + \mathcal{H}_b^+ \sum_m \mathbf{U}_{bm}$.
 - 8: **until** the maximum coefficient update is at most 10^{-8}
 - 9: Form the cluster sandwich covariance $\mathcal{H}_b^+ (\sum_m \mathbf{U}_{bm} \mathbf{U}_{bm}') \mathcal{H}_b^+$.
 - 10: Compute the robust Wald test for all condition coefficients.
 - 11: Permute condition once per mouse and repeat the complete GEE fit.
-

Algorithm 10 Laplace multinomial GLMM condition test

Require: Effective counts, nested designs, mouse labels, and random-effect dimension d_b

Ensure: Likelihood-ratio statistic and p-value

- 1: Integerize each effective count vector by largest remainder.
 - 2: **for all** null and alternative models **do**
 - 3: Initialize fixed coefficients from multinomial regression and initialize σ_b .
 - 4: **repeat**
 - 5: **for all** mice m **do**
 - 6: Find $\hat{\mathbf{u}}_{bm}$ with 30 damped Newton updates.
 - 7: Compute random-effect Hessian H_{bm} and its log determinant.
 - 8: **end for**
 - 9: Sum the Laplace log marginal likelihood and differentiate through the Newton updates.
 - 10: Update $\mathbf{B}_b$ and $\log \sigma_b$ by bounded L-BFGS.
 - 11: **until** the outer gradient tolerance or iteration limit is reached
 - 12: **end for**
 - 13: Compute twice the null-to-alternative Laplace log-likelihood gain.
 - 14: Compare with $\chi_{r_b d_b}^2$.
 - 15: For permutations, reuse the fitted null and refit each permuted alternative.
-

Algorithm 11 Nonbootstrap paired-EC Laplace block test

Require: Paired EC counts, compatibility matrices, nested tensors Z_{0b} , Z_{1b} , and mouse indices

Ensure: LRT p-value and BIC Bayes-factor approximation

- 1: Fit the null by maximizing its Laplace marginal log likelihood.
 - 2: Append q_b zero coefficients to the fitted null parameters.
 - 3: Warm-start and fit the alternative, re-estimating shared variance parameters.
 - 4: Set $D_b \leftarrow 2 \max\{0, \hat{\ell}_{1b}^{\text{Lap}} - \hat{\ell}_{0b}^{\text{Lap}}\}$.
 - 5: Set $p_b \leftarrow \Pr\{\chi_{q_b}^2 \geq D_b\}$.
 - 6: Set $\log \widehat{\text{BF}}_{10,b}^{\text{BIC}} \leftarrow (D_b - q_b \log M_g)/2$.
-

Algorithm 12 Inference comparison for the paired EC-count GLMM

Require: Paired counts $\mathbf{c}_{gip}$, maps A_{gp} , nested fixed-effect designs, mouse indices, likelihood family, and Rényi order $\alpha = 0.5$

Ensure: Null and alternative evidence approximations and coefficient estimates

- 1: **for all** null and alternative designs **do**
 - 2: Fit the conditional posterior mode of $u_g \in \mathbb{R}^{M_g \times d_g}$ by damped Newton updates.
 - 3: Optimize the Laplace marginal likelihood over B_g , $\log \sigma_g$, and optional $\log \kappa_g$.
 - 4: **if** the likelihood is multinomial **then**
 - 5: **repeat**
 - 6: Update every latent EC-to-isoform responsibility from $A_{gpkt} \exp(E_Q \eta_{git})$.
 - 7: Iterate every tilted coordinate a_{gip} to its softmax fixed point.
 - 8: Update $B_g, \mu_g, \log s_g, \log \sigma_g$ against the bounded ELBO; damp the global update when the bound decreases.
 - 9: **until** the ELBO gradient tolerance or iteration limit is reached
 - 10: **end if**
 - 11: Draw fixed antithetic standard-normal samples and reparameterize $u_g = \mu_g + s_g \odot \epsilon$.
 - 12: Optimize the exact-likelihood Monte Carlo ELBO $\mathcal{L}_1$.
 - 13: Warm-start from the ELBO fit and optimize $\mathcal{L}_{0.5}$; report its effective importance-sample size.
 - 14: **end for**
 - 15: Compare each method's null-to-alternative gain on its own objective; do not compare raw objective values across approximation families.
-

Algorithm 13 Block-specific paired EC-count GLMM cell-type test

Require: Block b , paired gene EC counts $\mathbf{c}_{gip}$, maps A_{gp} , condition design Z_b , cell-type design W_b , mouse indices, and R parametric-bootstrap replicates

Ensure: Empirically calibrated block p-value

- 1: Construct the Helmert basis Q_b and isoform-to-path contrast matrix H_b ; retain unmapped isoforms as likelihood nuisances.
 - 2: Form the null fixed-effect tensor from unrestricted condition-by- isoform coefficients $Z_b \otimes I_{d_g}$ and cell-type nuisance columns $W_{bij}(N_b)_{:s}$.
 - 3: Fit the null full-covariance posterior and variance parameters.
 - 4: Append the $(J_b - 1)d_b$ columns $W_{bij}(H_b)_{:s}$, warm-start all null parameters, and fit the observed alternative.
 - 5: Set $T_b \leftarrow 2(\mathcal{L}_{1b} - \mathcal{L}_{0b})$, using the same variational objective for both nested fits.
 - 6: **for** $r = 1, \dots, R$ **do**
 - 7: Draw mouse effects and optional observation effects from the fitted null; compute primer-specific EC probabilities.
 - 8: Generate multinomial or Dirichlet–multinomial EC counts while preserving every observed primer-row total.
 - 9: Refit the null, warm-starting from the observed null, then append the block-effect columns and fit the nested alternative.
 - 10: **end for**
 - 11: Pool converged bootstrap statistics by likelihood, tested dimension, and depth stratum, excluding block b 's replicates.
 - 12: Compute the finite-pool rank p-value and assess the same rank calculation on every null replicate before applying BH.
-

Algorithm 14 Matched semi-synthetic power benchmark

Require: Two-condition partitions, effect sizes γ , and replicate count R_{power}

Ensure: Asymptotic and null-calibrated power for each method

- 1: **for all** eligible blocks b **do**
 - 2: Draw and fix a unit ILR direction $\mathbf{v}_b$.
 - 3: **for** $r = 1, \dots, R_{\text{power}}$ **do**
 - 4: Permute condition labels among mice.
 - 5: **for all** nonzero effect sizes γ **do**
 - 6: Set $\mathbf{y}_{bmc}^{(r,\gamma)} = \mathbf{y}_{bmc} + \gamma z_{bmc}^{(r)} \mathbf{v}_b$.
 - 7: Map shifted ILRs to compositions and effective path counts.
 - 8: Fit GEE, GLMM, clustered GLS, and Dirichlet–multinomial tests.
 - 9: **end for**
 - 10: **end for**
 - 11: **end for**
 - 12: Rank each alternative statistic against null statistics for its block and method, using the finite-permutation correction.
 - 13: Report asymptotic and event-matched permutation rejection at 0.05.
-

Algorithm 15 Pairwise and dominant-path sensitivity tests

Require: Path estimates and conditional covariances from Algorithm 4**Ensure:** Calibrated sensitivity tables

- 1: **for all** cell-type pairs **do**
 - 2: Retain M mice containing both types.
 - 3: Use $X_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{2M \times M}$ for mouse effects and $X_1 \in \mathbb{R}^{2M \times (M+1)}$ for mouse plus cell type.
 - 4: Permute the two labels within mouse and correct across all block-by-pair hypotheses.
 - 5: **end for**
 - 6: **for all** blocks b **do**
 - 7: Rank paths by $\sum_i N_{bi}^{\text{gene}} \psi_{bis}$ and select $\mathcal{S}_b$, the two largest, without labels.
 - 8: Construct selector E_b , two-path basis $Q_b^{(2)}$, and $\mathcal{R}_b = (Q_b^{(2)})' E_b' Q_b$.
 - 9: Set $V_{bi}^{(2)} = \mathcal{R}_b V_{bi} \mathcal{R}_b'$ and renormalize the two retained proportions.
 - 10: Run Algorithm 8 and record path-floor sensitivity sweeps.
 - 11: **end for**
-

Algorithm 16 Joint condition tests

Require: Calibrated block-by-cell-type p-values or ILR responses**Ensure:** Partition- or gene-level joint p-values

- 1: For ACAT, combine valid cell-type p-values within a canonical partition; optionally combine partition p-values within a gene.
 - 2: As a negative control, fit one shared condition effect while treating cell-type rows as independent.
 - 3: For clustered GLS, construct diagonal covariance blocks $V_{bmc} + (\tau_{\text{mouse}}^2 + \tau_{\text{resid}}^2) I_{d_b}$ and same-mouse off-diagonal blocks $\tau_{\text{mouse}}^2 I_{d_b}$.
 - 4: Estimate τ_{mouse}^2 and τ_{resid}^2 by REML under the null.
 - 5: Fit the shared condition coefficient by GLS.
 - 6: **for all** mouse-level condition permutations **do**
 - 7: Apply one permuted condition to all cell types from that mouse and refit the model.
 - 8: **end for**
 - 9: Apply BH to the canonical-partition family; keep negative-control and calibrated results separate.
-

C Supporting Implementation Details

Splice-block construction

GTF exons are represented by zero-based, half-open intervals. Exon boundaries define atomic intervals; intervals exonic in every annotated spliced isoform are merged into constitutive anchors. Consecutive anchors define a block, and an isoform path is its ordered exon-interval chain between them. Terminal pseudo-anchors include alternative first and last regions. A gene without a shared constitutive region receives one whole-gene block.

Blocks with one path are discarded. Simple two-path blocks include skipped exons, mutually exclusive exons, alternative donors and acceptors, and retained introns. The implementation also supports nested and multi-path blocks. Precursor isoforms remain nuisance isoforms in the EC model but are not assigned to spliced paths.

Different genomic blocks can induce exactly the same partition of annotated isoforms, for example when several exons always occur together. Such blocks have identical statistical responses and must not count as repeated evidence. A canonical partition is the unordered collection of isoform sets assigned to paths. Equivalent blocks are collapsed before FDR or joint testing; all member interval identifiers remain in the output.

Pseudobulks and local fitting

Cell isoform proportions from the hierarchical decoder are weighted by cell UMI totals and aggregated by mouse, condition, and cell type. Pseudobulks must contain at least 20 cells and 10^5 total UMIs. A block is fit when its gene has at least 25 gene-assigned UMIs in at least two qualifying pseudobulks. Only ECs whose compatible isoforms map uniquely to that gene enter the local likelihood.

Bounded L-BFGS optimizes the paired multinomial likelihood, with $\|\delta_{bi}\|_\infty \leq 20$ to prevent floating-point underflow, where $\|\cdot\|_\infty$ is the maximum absolute component. Two-path fits are initialized from a log-ratio grid because the paired-primer normalizers can make the objective non-concave.

For the cell-resolved variant, sparse cell-by-EC matrices are retained and one local isoform matrix is decoded at a time. The optimizer dimension is still only the number of paths minus one. Cell-specific Fisher contributions are accumulated analytically, so the method does not fit one free splicing parameter per cell.

Identifiability and reliability

Finite Fisher covariance is not sufficient near a simplex boundary. Parametric bootstrap identified two reliability requirements:

$$\lambda_{\max}(V_{bi}) \leq 1/8 \quad \text{and} \quad \min_s \hat{\psi}_{bis} \geq 0.15.$$

Thus every tested log-ratio direction has effective information of at least eight and every fitted path has at least 15% usage. All estimates are written, together with convergence, identifiability, and reliability flags; only reliable estimates enter GLS. Here $\lambda_{\max}(V_{bi}) \in \mathbb{R}_+$ is the largest eigenvalue of the $d_b \times d_b$ covariance, and $\hat{\psi}_{bis} \in [0, 1]$ is path s 's fitted proportion.

D Supporting Results and Benchmarks

Condition-test scope

The primary analysis used the 25-gene-UMI cutoff and blocks with at most eight represented paths. It fit 10,100 blocks and 359,713 pseudobulk-by-block path estimates; 359,711 fits converged. After reliability filtering, there were 829 conditional and 506 profile tests.

These 1,335 rows represent 829 distinct block-by-cell-type hypotheses, covering 527 distinct splice blocks in eight cell types. The profile analysis is available for a subset of the conditional hypotheses. The possible conditions were 5xFAD, 5xFIRE, 5xFIRE PBS, 5xFIRE transplant, FIRE, and WT. For the 829 conditional hypotheses, 275 compared two conditions, 155 compared three, 153 compared four, 130 compared five, and 116 compared all six. The included set varies because every condition in a test must have at least three independent mouse pseudobulks for that block and cell type.

Condition-test results

No block was significant at 5% FDR in either covariance analysis. At the unadjusted $p < 0.05$ level:

- the conditional analysis identified 24 block-by-cell-type hypotheses, covering 21 distinct blocks;
- the profile analysis identified 20 block-by-cell-type hypotheses, covering 17 distinct blocks;
- 20 hypotheses were nominally significant in both analyses.

The union is 24 nominal block-by-cell-type hypotheses covering 21 blocks, but the corrected number of significant hypotheses and blocks is zero. Thus there is no FDR-significant evidence for condition-dependent splicing within cell type. The two covariance variants should not be added as if they were separate discoveries.

Formal mouse-clustered models

The shared-condition analysis was repeated with the multinomial-logit GLMM and Liang–Zeger GEE defined above. Clustered Gaussian ILR GLS and the unclustered Dirichlet–multinomial were refit to the same canonical partitions as comparators. Each block used 50 synchronized mouse-level null permutations. For 88 two-condition blocks, 50 semi-synthetic replicates were generated at each ILR effect size; 4,369 of 4,400 replicate designs had full rank. “Perm. nominal” below is the number of observed partitions with an event-matched permutation p-value at most 0.05. Table 3 summarizes the complete analysis.

Table 3: Calibration and power comparison. Null rejection uses asymptotic p-values on permuted labels; power uses event-matched permutation ranks.

Method	Tests	Conv.	Null < .05	Perm. nominal	Power .25	Power .50
Clustered GLS	359	359	0.025	17	0.171	0.322
Dirichlet–multinomial	359	359	0.138	18	0.188	0.364
Liang–Zeger GEE	359	355	0.415	8	0.139	0.268
Laplace GLMM	359	359	0.108	19	0.199	0.390

The canonical GEE sandwich reference is unusable at the available mouse counts: 41.5% of permuted-null p-values were below 0.05, and its apparent 116 asymptotic FDR discoveries are artifacts of this inflation. The GLMM reference was closer but still anti-conservative at 10.8%, while clustered GLS was conservative at 2.5%. Event-matched permutation calibration is therefore required for all comparisons. On that scale, the GLMM had the highest power, improving over clustered GLS by 2.8 and 6.9 percentage points at ILR effects 0.25 and 0.5. GEE was less powerful than clustered GLS after calibration. No method produced a permutation-calibrated 5% FDR discovery in the observed condition analysis.

EC-count GLMM inference benchmark

The EC-count methods were first compared in 96 independent simulations per likelihood and effect size. Each replicate had 12 mice, two observations per mouse, two isoforms, two distinct three-EC primer maps, 150 molecules per primer and observation, and mouse random-effect standard deviation 0.4. Dirichlet–multinomial simulations used concentration 30. The null threshold for each method was its own 95th percentile evidence gain at effect zero; power was evaluated at an

isoform logit effect of 0.5. This calibration is required because Laplace likelihoods, tilted ELBOs, and Rényi bounds are not numerically interchangeable objectives.

Table 4: Ambiguous-EC simulation comparison. RMSE is for the condition logit coefficient. Time is median seconds per nested null/alternative fit at effect 0.5. ESS is the median alternative mouse-level importance ESS out of 128.

Likelihood	Approximation	Null rejection	Power	RMSE	Time	ESS
Multinomial	Laplace	0.052	0.542	0.223	9.87	–
Multinomial	Tilted ELBO	0.052	0.542	0.223	1.87	–
Multinomial	Rényi $\alpha = 0.5$	0.052	0.542	0.223	1.58	127.67
Dirichlet–multinomial	Laplace	0.052	0.417	0.236	21.41	–
Dirichlet–multinomial	Monte Carlo ELBO	0.052	0.417	0.236	3.06	127.51
Dirichlet–multinomial	Rényi $\alpha = 0.5$	0.052	0.417	0.236	3.35	127.66

Within each likelihood family, all three approximations had the same empirically calibrated power to the reported precision, and their coefficient bias differed by less than 2×10^{-4} . The tilted bound’s null cutoff was 4.70, compared with 4.60 for multinomial Laplace and Rényi VI, but this small scale difference did not change rejection. Variational fitting was five- to seven-fold faster than Laplace. A single global importance weight over all mice had ESS 1/128 and collapsed the fitted random-effect variance; the mouse-factorized Rényi objective corrected this failure and produced ESS above 127.5/128 for both likelihoods.

A second simulation used three isoforms and otherwise retained the same 96 null and 96 effect replicates. Full-covariance and diagonal VI were nearly indistinguishable. Tilted evidence gains had Spearman correlation 0.9999 and median absolute difference 0.073 between posterior families; Rényi gains had correlation 0.99996 and median absolute difference 0.044. Every VI variant had calibrated power 0.438 and condition-coefficient RMSE 0.237–0.238. The full-covariance tilted fit took a median 2.43 seconds per nested effect fit versus 2.00 seconds for diagonal tilted VI. Thus, in a controlled multi-isoform setting, omitted posterior covariance was not a material source of error.

The same conclusion held for the direct EC Dirichlet–multinomial. In 96 three-isoform null and effect simulations, diagonal and full ELBO gains had correlation 0.9997 and median absolute difference 0.150; diagonal and full Rényi gains had correlation 0.9999 and median difference 0.092. Both posterior families had calibrated power 0.219. In the 65-gene real-data analysis, diagonal and full ELBO gains had correlations 0.998 for condition and 0.9998 for cell type, with median absolute differences 0.0035 and 0.0050. Fixed-draw Rényi optimization was again less stable than ELBO optimization.

The genome-wide paired-primer comparison retained 65 genes with mean depth at least 100 EC UMIs per pseudobulk; this was 65 of 66 depth-eligible genes, with one 3,905-EC outlier excluded by the 128-EC computational cap. All retained genes had at most six EC-supported isoforms. The authoritative run initialized each Gaussian variational posterior from the corresponding Laplace means and covariance diagonal, then initialized Rényi VI from the ELBO fit. Across the 65 condition models, convergence was 98.5% for both Laplace likelihoods, 95.4% for both ELBO variants, 92.3% for multinomial Rényi VI, and 98.5% for Dirichlet–multinomial Rényi VI. Cell-type convergence ranged from 93.8% to 100%. There were no fit exceptions.

Approximation agreement depended on isoform dimension. Among the 38 two-isoform genes, multinomial Laplace and Rényi evidence gains had Spearman correlation 0.974 for condition and 0.9996 for cell type; Laplace and tilted ELBO correlations were 0.969 and 0.9995. All 16 two-

isoform condition genes above the method-specific nominal threshold under multinomial Laplace were also above it under Rényi VI. For the 20 three-isoform genes, the analogous gain correlations fell to 0.49 and 0.59. The mean-field posterior has only a diagonal covariance across isoform random effects, whereas Laplace retains their within-mouse posterior covariance. The dimension-dependent divergence therefore motivated a full-covariance extension, but by itself did not distinguish covariance error from objective or optimizer differences. One-dimensional simulation thresholds were not applied to multi-isoform or cell-type omnibus tests.

The tilted surrogate must also be separated from objective evaluation. For two-isoform condition models, median nested gains were 5.54 for the tilted training bound, 4.95 for an exact-likelihood Monte Carlo ELBO evaluated at the same posterior, 4.93 for its Rényi evaluation, 4.93 for Laplace, and 4.95 for separately optimized Rényi VI. For cell type, the corresponding medians were 89.06, 74.38, 74.36, 72.12, and 74.36. Exact ELBO and Rényi gains on the same posterior had Spearman correlations 0.998 and 1.000 for condition and cell type. The tilted bound becomes looser under the larger alternative and therefore overstates nested evidence gains; it is retained as a fitting surrogate, not used as a likelihood-ratio statistic.

Full-covariance results did not support posterior covariance as the cause of the earlier multi-isoform discrepancy. On the real condition analysis, fresh-sample ELBO gains from diagonal and full tilted posteriors had Spearman correlation 0.991 across 65 genes and median absolute difference 0.002. Among the 20 three-isoform genes, the correlation was 0.938 and median difference was 0.024. The corresponding cell-type values were 1.000 overall and within the three-isoform subset, with median three-isoform difference 0.023. These results, together with the three-isoform simulation, point instead to differences in the Laplace objective or its outer optimization. Separately optimizing a fixed-draw full-covariance Rényi objective was less stable than fitting the tilted objective and evaluating both exact objectives with fresh draws; the latter is the reported comparison.

The observation-level logistic-normal model was validated with 96 null and 96 effect simulations using three isoforms, true residual standard deviation 0.6, and the same ambiguous paired-primer maps. Tilted full-covariance VI estimated median residual standard deviation 0.559 under the effect and had calibrated power 0.354. Dirichlet–multinomial Laplace had power 0.365, while the misspecified ordinary multinomial had power 0.313. Logistic-normal Laplace had power 0.146 despite estimating residual scale 0.472, indicating that its high-dimensional marginal approximation was not competitive with the tilted fit.

In the real data, tilted logistic-normal fits converged under both nested models for 80.0% of condition genes and 86.2% of cell-type genes. The alternative residual standard deviation had median 0.040 for condition and 0.029 for cell type; the respective interquartile ranges were 0.007–0.239 and 0.006–0.234. Relative to the multinomial full posterior, fresh ELBO condition gains changed by a median absolute 0.335 and retained rank correlation 0.809. Cell-type gains changed by 10.68 and retained correlation 0.959, consistent with extra-multinomial variation having more impact on the larger cell-type omnibus statistic. Because residual-scale estimates often approached zero and convergence was weaker, this model is retained as an overdispersion sensitivity analysis rather than replacing the primary test.

The initial block-specific EC analysis inherited 406 coverage-eligible partitions from the path-count analysis and tested 399 after EC identifiability filtering. This was unnecessarily restrictive because it required reliable path estimates before fitting the EC likelihood. The genome-wide EC screen instead counts exactly the primer-specific EC rows in the likelihood, retains cell types represented in at least three mice, and requires at least two represented cell types. The strict rule additionally requires at least 25 gene UMIs and 30 covered pseudobulks; the permissive rule requires at least 10 gene UMIs. These rules retain 1,926 and 5,650 blocks, respectively. Five parametric-bootstrap replicates per block provide pooled null distributions matched by tested di-

mension. Table 5 reports the calibrated tests.

Table 5: Parametric-bootstrap-calibrated cell-type tests using gene EC counts. The depth column gives the range of null rejection rates across independent gene-depth quartiles. MN is multinomial, LN is logistic-normal multinomial, and DM is Dirichlet-multinomial.

Coverage	Likelihood	Tests	Conv.	Nominal	FDR	Null < .05	Depth range
Strict	MN	1,926	1.000	415	174	0.0496	0.0480–0.0505
Strict	LN	1,926	0.991	377	157	0.0498	0.0439–0.0541
Strict	DM	1,926	0.988	145	0	0.0491	0.0454–0.0582
Permissive	MN	5,650	0.999	997	294	0.0497	0.0475–0.0519
Permissive	LN	5,650	0.984	974	193	0.0497	0.0428–0.0541
Permissive	DM	5,650	0.989	421	0	0.0498	0.0456–0.0516

The permissive rule increases absolute discoveries from 174 to 294 for MN and from 157 to 193 for LN, while testing 2.9 times as many blocks. MN and LN share 152 strict and 192 permissive discoveries. DM has no genome-wide FDR discoveries under either rule despite acceptable calibration. On the 1,926 shared hypotheses, applying BH only to that common family gives 316 MN, 265 LN, and 40 DM discoveries under the permissive fits, versus 174, 157, and zero under the strict fits. Thus lower-count rows add signal, but much of that gain is spent on the larger genome-wide hypothesis family. The corresponding strict-versus-permissive statistic rank correlations are 0.781, 0.764, and 0.760, so changing the cutoff also changes individual fits rather than only the BH denominator.

Expanded EC likelihood and coverage comparison

The final analysis uses one likelihood and testing construction for both biological contrasts: the logistic-normal multinomial block EC GLMM. For the cell-type test, condition indicators are nuisance fixed effects and the alternative adds block-path-by-cell-type interactions. For the condition test, models are fit separately within each cell type; the null has an intercept fixed effect and the alternative adds block-path-by-condition interactions. Both versions retain a mouse random effect and paired primer-specific EC likelihoods. Every retained condition must be represented by at least three mice, and every tested pseudobulk must have at least 10 modeled gene UMIs.

The annotation-level block equivalence relation is insufficient after EC screening: removing unsupported isoforms can make two distinct annotated blocks induce exactly the same partition of the remaining isoforms. The final hypothesis family therefore retains one representative for each tuple of gene, EC-supported isoforms, canonical block-path partition, covered observations, and tested factor levels. This reduces the permissive cell-type family from 5,650 to 4,825 tests and the condition family from 17,685 to 14,833 block-by-cell-type tests over 5,608 representative blocks. This collapse is performed before calibration and BH correction.

Table 6: The unified, nonredundant logistic-normal block EC GLMM after cross-fitted tail calibration. Condition tests are within cell type. Robust calls are significant at every tail threshold from 80% through 95%.

Contrast	Tests	Conv.	Nominal	FDR	Robust	Null < .05	Null < .01	Null < .001
Cell type	4,825	0.983	751	243	237	0.04994	0.00999	0.00098
Condition	14,833	1.000	1,415	0	0	0.04999	0.00999	0.00099

The initial empirical calibration compared each test only with its degrees-of-freedom-specific bootstrap pool. After supported-partition deduplication, its minimum attainable p-values were

approximately 4.5×10^{-4} , whereas BH requires resolution near 10^{-5} at the first ranks. Its zero logistic-normal calls were therefore a bootstrap-tail resolution artifact, not disappearance of the cell-type signal.

The final calibration fits a generalized Pareto peaks-over-threshold model within each degrees-of-freedom stratum. Fits are cross-fitted by holding out whole block tests. The resulting observed and held-out-null tail scores are then recalibrated by a global leave-block-out empirical null CDF. This second stage corrects residual tail-model bias and gives sufficient pooled resolution for genome-wide BH. At a 90% threshold, multinomial, logistic-normal multinomial, and Dirichlet–multinomial EC tests identify 272, 243, and 59 nonredundant cell-type partitions. Logistic-normal thresholds of 80%, 85%, 90%, and 95% give 243, 242, 243, and 239 calls; 237 occur in all four sets, 229 of those are multinomial calls, and 44 are called by all three likelihoods.

Condition is less stable. The same four thresholds give 27, 27, zero, and zero calls, with no partition in all four sets; at the 90% threshold the minimum FDR is 0.0637. The final conclusion is therefore strong calibrated cell-type DS, but no robust condition DS. The earlier 193 logistic-normal calls in Table 5 used annotation-level duplicates and under-resolved empirical tails and are superseded by the 237 robust set.

Cell-type effects within mouse

The initial Gaussian analysis tested 369 conditional and 218 profile partitions. It found 22 and five FDR-significant partitions, respectively, with all profile discoveries contained in the conditional set. After canonicalizing annotation intervals that encode the same isoform-to-path partition, these 22 intervals represented 14 distinct partitions.

The compositional analysis used converged, conditionally identifiable estimates and required every modeled path proportion to be at least 5%. This produced 646 nonredundant tests. A minimum of 30 pseudobulk observations per partition, chosen as a label-effect-independent coverage requirement, retained 406 hypotheses for FDR correction. Among these, 149 had exact permutation $p < 0.05$, and **101 splice-path partitions in 95 genes passed 5% FDR**. Thirteen of the 14 nonredundant Gaussian discoveries were recovered; the remaining partition had exact $p = 0.032$ but FDR 0.098. Significant compositional results had median maximum cell-type logit effect 0.84 and median effective path count 21.7.

The observation-count threshold is not a narrow boundary effect: thresholds from 29 through 32 pseudobulks each gave 101 discoveries, while 33 gave 99. All 646 observed fits converged. The median number of valid permutations was 500; the minimum was 476 after excluding failed permutation refits. Asymptotic Dirichlet–multinomial p-values were anti-conservative, with 15.5% of permutation-null values below 0.05, which is why only exact per-event permutation ranks are used for the primary result.

Two sensitivity analyses did not improve the event-level result. Testing 3,708 individual cell-type pairs gave 97 FDR-significant pair hypotheses but only 32 distinct partitions after correction across all pairs. Restricting each block to its two molecule-weighted dominant paths increased coverage; with a 1% path floor it gave 88 discoveries, and removing the floor gave 91, under a cross-fitted empirical null. These analyses support the full-path exact omnibus test as the primary cell-type analysis.

Allowing the alternative to re-estimate κ also left the result unchanged: it found the same 101 partitions in the same 95 genes, with no event entering or leaving the 5% FDR set. Exact p-values from fixed- and free-concentration fits had Spearman correlation 0.9995, and both had 148 nominal events. The null optimum was multinomial for 499 of 646 tests, and the alternative optimum was multinomial for 580. Among 66 tests with finite concentration in both models, the median

alternative/null concentration ratio was 1.54, consistent with cell-type mean effects explaining some apparent overdispersion. Exact permutation calibration absorbs this nuisance-parameter flexibility, so freeing κ provides no net power gain here.

Calibration

Across the 25-UMI analysis, 2.7% of permuted-label Wald p-values were below 0.05 for both conditional and profile covariance, indicating conservative null calibration. A parametric bootstrap of 3,000 reliable local fits gave mean squared standardized error 1.10 and 94.5% coverage for nominal 95% intervals. Independent Gaussian simulations of REML-GLS gave type-I error between 2.7% and 5.0% across the tested biological-variance settings.

Numerical tests additionally verify skipped-exon block construction, identifiable covariance after collapsing indistinguishable isoforms, rejection of information-null path contrasts, the analytic binomial Fisher variance, and recovery of imposed GLS effects.

Coverage-cutoff sensitivity

UMIs	blocks	tests	conditional null $p < .05$	profile null $p < .05$	bootstrap coverage
25	10100	1335	0.027	0.027	0.945
50	5896	755	0.031	0.030	0.936
100	2820	283	0.029	0.025	0.946
200	1034	69	0.028	0.026	0.948
500	195	10	0.030	0.050	0.946

No cutoff produced an FDR-significant block. The 500-UMI calibration estimate is based on only 100 permutation tests.

For reliable two-condition, two-path conditional tests, mean asymptotic power for a 0.5 ILR effect was 0.49, 0.51, 0.44, 0.56, and 0.59 at increasing cutoffs. The final two values are selected from only eight and two eligible tests. Among 103 hypotheses shared by the 25- and 50-UMI analyses, power was 0.453 and 0.449. Lower coverage cutoffs therefore increase the number of testable blocks without degrading calibrated precision among shared tests. The 25-UMI cutoff is the default.

Does cell resolution increase condition-test power?

The cell-resolved likelihood was run on the 527 blocks testable in the 25-UMI primary analysis. All 41,242 block-by-pseudobulk fits converged; 21,624 passed the reliability rules, compared with 21,010 pseudobulk conditional estimates on the same blocks. This produced 836 condition tests, compared with 829 for pseudobulk fitting. No cell-resolved test passed 5% FDR. Condition-label permutations were conservative, with 2.49% of null p-values below 0.05.

An exact matched comparison used the same reliable samples for both methods in 807 block-by-cell-type tests. Cell resolution reduced the median local covariance trace by 1.6%, and the median path-response RMS difference was 0.033 ILR units. P-values were strongly concordant (Spearman rank correlation 0.958); 24 pseudobulk and 25 cell-resolved tests were nominally significant.

For the 259 matched two-condition, two-path tests, mean asymptotic power for a 0.5 ILR effect was 0.504 for both methods. The median ratio of cell-resolved to pseudobulk condition-coefficient standard error was 0.995. Retaining cell likelihood terms therefore did not materially increase power in this dataset. The aggregated EC counts and decoder baseline preserve nearly all relevant

local information within a cell type, while residual between-mouse variation dominates the small reduction in inferential variance. Pseudobulk fitting remains the default; the cell-resolved method is available for datasets with stronger within-pseudobulk isoform heterogeneity.

Compositional and joint-test assessment

Collapsing equivalent isoform partitions reduced the 829 conditional block-by-cell-type rows to 505 nonredundant tests over 317 partitions. The median effective path count was 32 molecules, or 62% of gene UMIs; only 0.6% of estimates reached the gene-UMI cap.

On the same 505 tests, conditional GLS had 12 nominal results and the Dirichlet–multinomial had 18. Neither had a 5% FDR discovery. The Dirichlet–multinomial was conservatively calibrated: 3.76% of 10,100 permuted-label p-values were below 0.05. In contrast, pure multinomial regression gave 197 nominal and 155 FDR results, but 39.1% of its permutation p-values were below 0.05. UMI sampling alone therefore cannot represent the large between-mouse compositional variation. Output tables mark pure multinomial and naive shared-effect rows as invalid for inference while retaining them as calibration diagnostics.

ACAT across cell types produced 8 nominal GLS and 12 nominal Dirichlet–multinomial partitions among 317 tests, with no FDR discoveries. Combining distinct partitions within genes gave 7 and 11 nominal genes among 276 tests, again with no FDR discoveries.

Naive shared-effect pooling illustrates the pseudoreplication risk. It gave 43 nominal and one FDR Dirichlet–multinomial partition, but synchronized mouse permutations rejected 13.2% of nulls at 0.05. The apparent discovery had asymptotic $p = 6.4 \times 10^{-5}$ but permutation $p = 0.143$. Naive shared GLS was also inflated, with 8.4% null rejection.

The mouse-clustered shared GLS restored conservative calibration: 2.19% of 7,169 synchronized permutation p-values were below 0.05. It produced 11 nominal partitions among 359 tests and no FDR discoveries; its smallest p-value was 0.0126 with FDR 0.86. Gene-level ACAT gave 9 nominal genes among 313 and no FDR discoveries. Thus the calibrated gain is limited to the increase from 12 to 18 nominal within-cell-type tests under the Dirichlet–multinomial. None of the evaluated strategies creates a genome-wide condition discovery in this dataset.

E Limitations and Extensions

The profile covariance is conditional on the fitted genome-wide decoder. Uncertainty in shared decoder parameters is expected to be small for common paths but may matter for rare genes or cell types. A mouse-level jackknife of the hierarchical fit is the preferred extension.

The current biological variance is isotropic in log-ratio space. Estimating a full covariance separately for every block would be unstable with few mice. A later empirical-Bayes model could shrink path-specific biological covariances across genes.